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<i>President:</i>	Mr. Kariuki	(United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland)
<i>Members:</i>	Albania	Mr. Spasse
	Brazil	Mr. Muniz Pinto Sloboda
	China	Mr. Gu Wenlong
	Ecuador	Mr. Durán Medina
	France	Ms. Freudenreich
	Gabon	Mr. Diaba
	Ghana	Mrs. Corquaye
	Japan	Mr. Magosaki
	Malta	Ms. Micallef
	Mozambique	Mr. Buanahagi
	Russian Federation	Mr. Vorobiev
	Switzerland	Mr. Hauri
	United Arab Emirates	Ms. AlMatrooshi
	United States of America	Ms. Brosnan

Agenda

Children and armed conflict

How to prevent and respond to grave violations against children in armed conflict

Report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363)

Letter dated 23 June 2023 from the Permanent Representative of the United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland to the United Nations addressed to the Secretary-General (S/2023/470)

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The meeting was resumed at 3.05 p.m.

The President: I would like to remind all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to enable the Council to carry out its work expeditiously. Flashing lights on the collars of the microphones will prompt speakers to bring their statements to a close after three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Luxembourg.

Mr. Maes (Luxembourg) (*spoke in French*): Luxembourg aligns itself with the statements to be made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends on Children and Armed Conflict. I would like to add some considerations in my national capacity.

I would like to thank the United Kingdom presidency of the Security Council for organizing today's open debate, and this morning's briefers for explaining what is at stake.

We cannot ignore the alarming situation of children trapped in armed conflicts around the world. In 2022, 18,890 children were victims of 24,300 grave violations in 25 situations. These are the confirmed figures for last year. The real figure is certainly much higher.

A striking example of this reality is Ukraine, where children are directly affected by the use of missile systems by Russian forces, bombardments of populated areas and air strikes by the aggressor. These disproportionate attacks have devastating consequences on the lives of innocent children, causing loss of life, serious injury and indelible trauma for this generation.

Other situations are equally alarming. Luxembourg is particularly concerned at the deteriorating situation of children in South Sudan and Myanmar. In such countries as Syria, Yemen and the occupied Palestinian territory, the lack of access to humanitarian aid is having disastrous consequences for children trapped in protracted conflicts. Those children, already vulnerable, face daily challenges to their survival, particularly young girls who are victims of sexual violence.

A particularly worrisome trend is the 112 per cent increase in the number of attacks on schools and hospitals. In 2022 alone, 1,163 attacks on schools were recorded. Luxembourg actively supports the Safe Schools Declaration and urges all States that have not yet done so to endorse it, in order to prevent such attacks and protect places of learning. Schools must

remain zones of peace. To deprive children of their fundamental right to education is to deprive them of their future.

I would like to reiterate Luxembourg's financial and political support for the mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, and all her teams. Their essential work with United Nations country teams helps to document violations of children's rights in armed conflicts. Their mission is crucial.

Luxembourg remains deeply attached to this theme, as demonstrated by the fact that, together with Belgium, Malta and Uruguay, we recently organized a photography exhibition in Geneva entitled "From Despair to Hope: Children Beyond Armed Conflict", in conjunction with the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict.

It is our duty to strengthen accountability mechanisms in order to put an end to impunity for serious violations committed against children. Children deserve our commitment, our compassion and above all our resolute action to build a better and safer future for all.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Greece.

Mr. Sekeris (Greece): It is a great pleasure for Greece to participate in today's open debate on children and armed conflict. I would like to warmly thank the United Kingdom for organizing this timely meeting, which provides with us an excellent opportunity to reflect on the findings of the most recent annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363). I would also like to warmly thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter, as well as the Deputy Executive Director of UNICEF for the very interesting briefings this morning.

While fully aligning myself with the statement to be delivered later by the European Union, please allow me to make some additional remarks in my national capacity.

Unfortunately, in 2022, children continued to be disproportionately affected by armed conflict, and the number of children affected by grave violations increased in comparison to 2021. Against this backdrop, as the Secretary-General stresses in his report, it is of

utmost importance that children, even those allegedly associated with armed groups, be treated primarily as victims. Consequently, child protection should be effectively mainstreamed throughout the conflict cycle, from early warning to disarmament, demobilization and reintegration. Moreover, the support provided by the donor community should be timely, gender- and age-sensitive, survivor-centred and inclusive, addressing the specific needs of children victims of grave violations, focusing on girls and on children with disabilities.

Greece places particular emphasis on the protection of children in armed conflict, having already ratified the relevant Optional Protocol to the Convention of the Rights of the Child, and having endorsed the Paris Principles, the Safe Schools Declaration and the Vancouver Principles. Furthermore, Greece has been duly implementing its national action plans on the rights of the child and on the protection of children from sexual exploitation and abuse as well as its comprehensive national strategy on the protection of unaccompanied minors. Additionally, the promotion of the children and armed conflict agenda is one of the main priorities of my country's candidacy as an elected member of the Security Council for the 2025–2026 term.

Finally, I would like to reiterate my country's principled positions in favour of protecting the rights and dignity of conflict-affected children and of preventing grave violations against these children, in close cooperation with all relevant stakeholders as a necessary precondition of a peaceful, inclusive and resilient world.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Austria.

Mr. Almoslechner (Austria): Austria thanks the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate and fully aligns itself with the statements to be made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends on Children and Armed Conflict.

We also wish to thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2023/363) and commend the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter. Furthermore, we pay tribute to the members of the country task forces of the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism for their indispensable work.

More than 25 years ago, the children and armed conflict agenda was created with the aim of preventing grave violations against children in armed conflicts and holding perpetrators to account through global commitments. While we have seen some important progress in that regard, the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/363) for 2022 paints a bleak picture indeed. The evidence suggests that the situation is worsening on a global scale. As the number of armed conflicts continues to surge around the world, the number of children suffering and disproportionately bearing the brunt of war is increasing.

Austria is appalled by the growing number of verified grave violations. The overall increase in attacks against schools, hospitals and protected personnel, as well as the denial of humanitarian assistance and the use of explosive weapons in populated areas, is truly horrifying. Moreover, the report's finding that Government forces are now the main perpetrators of the killing and maiming of children, attacks on schools and hospitals and the denial of humanitarian assistance is particularly disheartening.

We are extremely concerned about the country situations in the report, including those that were most recently added, and the largest increases in verified grave violations in Myanmar, South Sudan and Burkina Faso, among other places. And the truly shocking numbers reported represent only the tip of the iceberg — the small percentage of cases that the United Nations can verify. We all know that the grave figures that remain unreported are much higher.

For example, as a result of Russia's unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression on Ukraine, the Commission of Inquiry on Ukraine has documented massive human rights violations against children in Ukraine, including killings, maiming, torture, rape, abductions and forced displacement. For the countless children who have lost their families and loved ones, and those who can no longer access education or health care, the consequences are devastating. They have been brutally robbed of their childhood. Austria calls on the Russian Federation, as well as all the other Government authorities and parties to the conflict listed in the Secretary-General's report, to grant full access to the United Nations to verify children and armed conflict violations. We also strongly condemn all forms of intimidation, violence and attacks against child protection advisers, monitoring teams and all other stakeholders involved.

All Member States, as well as other parties to conflicts, must respect international law, international humanitarian law, refugee law and international human rights obligations, as well as international child protection norms. The rule of law is what ultimately makes our very complex world more predictable, reliable, safe and orderly. It is an indispensable precondition for sustainable peace and security. Those responsible for grave violations against children must be brought to justice through swift investigations. Austria reiterates its full and unwavering support for the International Criminal Court.

We encourage all Member States that have not yet done so to adhere to the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict and to endorse the Vancouver Principles, the Paris Principles and Commitments and the Safe School Declaration. Child protection should also be a part of the predeployment training of all peacekeepers. For Austrian peacekeepers, such training is obligatory.

Since gender norms shape the way that children are exposed to grave violations, gender-sensitive protection schemes are particularly important. As a member of the International Network on Conflict and Fragility of the Development Assistance Committee of the Organization for Economic Cooperation and Development, Austria supports a systematic gender-sensitive approach to all humanitarian and conflict prevention measures. In that regard, let me also commend the efforts of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General on Sexual Violence in Conflict, Ms. Pramila Patten.

We must stop any further backsliding of the children and armed conflict agenda. The past two and a half decades have shown that, when parties to conflict decide to abide by their international-law obligations and child protection commitments, crimes against children can be prevented. We therefore welcome the signing of handover protocols by parties to conflict, as well as the support to children formerly associated with armed forces or armed groups through protection or reintegration programmes.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Slovenia.

Ms. Jurečko (Slovenia): I would like to thank the United Kingdom for convening today's important open debate, and the briefers for their statements.

Slovenia aligns itself with the statements made on behalf on the European Union and the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

A lot of progress has been made since the United Nations began its consideration of children and armed conflict agenda for the very first time. The development of a vast set of tools led to the creation of a strong normative framework for the protection of children. We underline the importance of this annual open debate and the children and armed conflict mandate in the United Nations peace and security architecture. The independent, impartial and credible Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism, together with Working Group of the Security Council and the annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363), form essential pillars of that framework as well. Despite all those efforts, children continue to be disproportionately affected in armed conflicts.

We welcome the Secretary-General's annual report and are deeply concerned about increasing number of children affected by grave violations, as well as the higher number of situations in which violations are occurring. We are particularly concerned about the situations in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Israel and the State of Palestine, Somalia, Syria, Ukraine, Afghanistan and Yemen, where the highest numbers of grave violations were reported in 2022. We are appalled by the information on the systemic violations of international humanitarian law and international human rights law. In that regard, we call on all parties to conflict to uphold their obligations and respect for international law. Combating impunity and ensuring accountability remain our priority. In that respect, we encourage cooperation with the International Criminal Court and other international justice mechanisms and call for child-rights expertise within those mechanisms.

Global initiatives such as the Paris Principles and the Vancouver Principles, the Safe Schools Declaration and the recently adopted Ljubljana-The Hague Convention on International Cooperation in the Investigation and Prosecution of Genocide, Crimes Against Humanity, War Crimes and Other International Crimes can provide additional tools to protect children's rights and strengthen child protection. We encourage all Member States to further their commitments by endorsing those instruments.

We are worried about the report's findings stating that the use of explosive devices and their remnants represent some 26 per cent of the methods used in the

killing and maiming of children. In that regard, we call on Member States to enhance efforts for clearing explosive remnants of war and to invest more in explosive-ordnance risk education.

Slovenia has a long tradition of supporting efforts to protect children affected by armed conflicts. Our Government has been financing various projects in that regard, including for the clearance of landmines and explosive remnants of war and for reintegration, rehabilitation, health-care and psychosocial services for children from Ukraine, Moldova, Lebanon, Palestine, Syria, South Sudan and Afghanistan.

We are pleased that today we were able to hear a young girl's voice in the Security Council. Allow me to take this opportunity to encourage the Council to continue providing space for children to have a voice in peace processes and to prioritize child protection in all areas of its work.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Thailand.

Mr. Chindawongse (Thailand): I would like to congratulate the United Kingdom on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for the month of July and to commend the United Arab Emirates for its successful presidency of the Council last month. I want to thank the United Kingdom for convening this important open debate, as well as the Secretary-General for his recent report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). I thank all the briefers for their contributions to our discussion today.

It is alarming that, according to the report of the Secretary-General, in 2022 the number of children affected by grave violations increased as compared to 2021. Thailand joins other speakers in condemning all forms of violations and crimes against children in situations of armed conflict, because coming from a country that has provided safe havens for tens of thousands of children fleeing armed conflict over the past decades, we Thais have been close witnesses to and fully understand the harm that befalls children when conflicts occur. It is a harm that should always be prevented — because children are our future. As such, they should be accorded the necessary protection so that they can indeed have a future. And if they have a future, so will we. It is with that hope for a better future for children affected by armed conflict that Thailand

underscores the importance of scaling up prevention and response efforts and, in that regard, would like to underscore the following four points.

First, we must ensure strict compliance with and promote States' commitment to implementing the provisions of international law for the protection of children in armed conflict, including those contained in the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its Optional Protocol, as well as international humanitarian law and other relevant international human rights law.

Secondly, the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism (MRM) plays a crucial role in the early detection of violations and paves the way for early engagement with parties to conflicts as part of prevention efforts. It will help the international community to better address the challenges faced by children in a more comprehensive manner. Therefore, in addition to the six grave violations that have been identified as priority areas for the MRM, we also support efforts to monitor and respond to other violations.

Thirdly, we believe that effective data-collection and data-sharing are crucial. Data collected should be age- and sex- disaggregated, as much as possible, because boys and girls, across various age-groups, experience conflicts differently. That will enable us to scale up appropriate responsive measures required for effective prevention, response, recovery and sustainable reintegration.

Lastly, sustained support for the recovery and rehabilitation of children affected by armed conflict is critical. In that regard, we need both hardware and software. On the one hand, the infrastructure, health facilities and nutritional support are all critical to rebuilding children's physical health, as are psychological support, education, continued learning opportunities and the care of communities to rebuild shattered lives and mental well-being, on the other. Special attention must also be given to help children who have suffered from sexual violence, which is exacerbated during times of armed conflict and has a disproportionate effect on girls.

All such efforts are necessary to ensure sustainable reintegration and the prevention of re-victimization so that the children affected can have hope for a better future that is sustainable. Having a better future for children should naturally be an integral part of our summed-up future aspirations. If their future is secured, our future will also be secured.

In order to help such a better future for children, we will need coordinated efforts across and among all stakeholders, including national Governments, civil society organizations and affected communities in strengthening the protection of the rights and well-being of children. We commend the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict for her continued engagement with the international community, partners and relevant parties.

In conclusion, we all love and care for our children, which is part of being a human being. But we can also love and care for all children. That is what it means to be part of humankind. Thailand therefore stands ready to share its experiences and best practices that could help enhance our collective efforts to protect children's rights and strengthen child protection, as well as address the root causes of conflicts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Italy.

Mr. Massari (Italy): I would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing this annual open debate, and the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, and the Deputy Director for Programmes of UNICEF for their informative briefings.

Italy aligns itself with the statement to be delivered on behalf of the European Union and the statement made by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Groups of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict. I would like to add the following remarks in my national capacity.

In line with the Convention on the Rights of the Child, children, regardless of their legal status, must have the right to enjoy their childhood in stable and peaceful societies, where they can feel safe to learn and become agents of positive change, peace and sustainable development. In that spirit, we express our deep concern about the increasing number of verified grave violations in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) for 2022. It is particularly disturbing to witness the rising trend of violations carried out by State actors, while States have the primary responsibility to protect, respect and ensure children's rights both in times of peace and war. In that regard, the foundation of international law and international humanitarian law is under deliberate attack, and the international community must reaffirm its commitment to respect for international law, human rights and humanitarian principles.

In that framework, Italy recalls the Paris Principles and the Vancouver Principles and calls on all Member States to endorse and fully implement the Safe Schools Declaration in order to mitigate the consequences of armed conflict on education and refrain from the military use of civil infrastructure. In parallel, we must not disregard crimes that are largely underreported, such as sexual violence in conflict and rape used as a tactic of war. We encourage maximum collaboration across the different United Nations mandates to prevent and end that scourge and ensure that the perpetrators are brought to justice. We reiterate our staunch support for the children and armed conflict mandate, as a unique tool to mainstream child protection on the political agenda of the Security Council. We welcome the progress registered by Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and note with concern the challenges highlighted in the Lake Chad basin, the central Sahel and other regions.

Italy is proud to have supported the United Nations guidance note on abduction and stands ready to respond to the Secretary-General's call to address the specific needs of children with disabilities and support the ongoing efforts of the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General in that direction. We take note of the listing of the Russian armed forces and affiliates following Russia's unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression against Ukraine. We urge all parties to accelerate the implementation of joint action plans through credible and effective measures aimed at protecting children as the highest priority. Indeed, the children and armed conflict mandate is a key tool to encourage change in the behaviour of the parties, without ever underestimating their responsibilities for actions taken and the moral and legal call to end impunity.

In conclusion, we share the concerns expressed by the Secretary-General in his report on the children transferred to the Russian Federation from areas of Ukraine. We encourage all possible efforts aimed at facilitating family tracing and reunification, and we call on all parties to the conflict to give child protection actors access to the children to facilitate the process, in line with the actual best interests of every child.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Croatia.

Mr. Šimonović (Croatia): We thank the United Kingdom for organizing today's important open debate. We also express our gratitude to the briefers.

Croatia aligns itself with the statement to be delivered on behalf of the European Union and the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict. I would like to add some remarks in my national capacity.

We welcome the latest report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). The dramatic increase in attacks on schools and hospitals is particularly alarming. We are appalled that Government forces were the main perpetrators of most violations. They are blatantly failing in upholding their responsibility to protect. The lack of respect for international human rights law and international humanitarian law has become all too common. We fully support the United Nations and the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict in their efforts to constructively engage with all parties to all conflicts and encourage developing strong action plans to end current violations and prevent future ones. We welcome the progress made with the new joint action plans in Yemen and Iraq, as well as other positive developments with regard to the repatriation of children and the adoption of handover protocols. I would also like to thank UNICEF and civil society partners for their dedicated work in high-risk settings. We must do everything we can to protect children affected by conflicts, especially girls, who are particularly vulnerable, as potential victims of sexual violence.

We strongly advocate for accountability for grave violations, as that is the key to achieving sustainable peace. The United Nations-led Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism is a reliable and objective source of information, drawing attention to committed violations. Together with the Secretary-General's annual report and its annex, it represents an important accountability tool and helps prevent further violations against children. It also serves as a warning shot for their perpetrators that listed violations may be prosecuted.

Finally, we call on all parties to end violence against children and abide by their obligations under international law. Croatia reiterates its full commitment

to advancing the children and armed conflict agenda and encourages all States to endorse the Paris Principles, the Vancouver Principles and the Safe Schools Declaration.

The President: I now give the floor to Mr. Skoog.

Mr. Skoog: I congratulate the United Kingdom on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month. I thank you, Sir, for organizing this debate and the invitation to participate.

I will speak on behalf of the European Union and its member States. The candidate countries North Macedonia, Montenegro, Albania, the Republic of Moldova and Bosnia and Herzegovina; the potential candidate Georgia; as well as Monaco and San Marino, align themselves with this statement. I will make an abbreviated statement, given the many speakers remaining on the list.

We welcome the Secretary-General's 2023 report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). We are deeply alarmed by the more than 27,000 grave violations around the world, and we also realize that that is just the verifiable tip of the iceberg. Earlier today, Ms. Violeta gave a testimony about Colombia and on the broader effects of all such violations on children and on all societies. I want to thank her for being here. I also want to thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and the Deputy Executive Director for Programmes of UNICEF for their briefings today and for the work that they are all doing.

Children should never be victims of conflict. We know how difficult it is to get non-State armed groups to comply with the law in this area, but we are particularly dismayed at Russia's part in such violations through its full-scale aggression against Ukraine and its regular State army. There should be zero tolerance of violations of international human rights law and international humanitarian law, and we therefore call on all States to bring to justice all who are responsible for such violations and encourage them to cooperate with international justice mechanisms, including the International Criminal Court. I want to briefly highlight a few points.

First, we recognize the importance of the work of the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, UNICEF, all United Nations child-protection actors and civil-society organizations. They need to be supported and provided with adequate resources.

Secondly, we welcome the signing of new joint action plans on prevention, including in Yemen with the Houthis, and in Iraq. Follow-through is needed.

Thirdly, the children and armed conflict mandate is very valuable. We underline the importance of clear criteria and procedures in decisions to list and delist parties. We note new listing decisions on the Russian armed forces and their affiliates in Ukraine, as well as in Burkina Faso and Myanmar.

Fourthly, Russia's unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression has also taken a devastating toll on children. We urge the Russian Federation to abide by its obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law and to immediately, completely and unconditionally withdraw all of its troops and military equipment from the entire territory of Ukraine, within its internationally recognized borders. For many Ukrainian children the damage is already done, but withdrawal would be the best way to end the ongoing violations.

Fifthly, we look forward to the swift implementation of the joint action plan agreed on with Russia and Ukraine. We also echo the Secretary-General's recommendation to give child-protection actors access to children transferred to Russia in order to facilitate family reunification.

Lastly, we are also closely following the situations in the Niger and Haiti, both newly designated as being of concern.

Under international law, States have the primary responsibility to protect, respect and ensure children's rights, in time of peace and of war. We expect the Security Council and its individual members to uphold its mandate under the relevant resolutions. We need to strengthen the mandate and make a stronger link to protection and respect for international law and to combating the climate of impunity.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Guatemala.

Ms. Rodríguez Mancia (Guatemala) (*spoke in Spanish*): Guatemala thanks the United Kingdom for convening today's important open debate, which provides an opportunity to analyse the findings of the Secretary-General's annual report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). We also appreciate the briefings made earlier today by the Special

Representative of the Secretary-General, the Deputy Executive Director for Programmes at UNICEF and the civil-society youth representative, Ms. Violeta.

We thank the Secretary-General for his report, pursuant to resolution 2427 (2018), which describes the alarming trends related to the impact of armed conflict on children, including information on grave violations that have been committed. Fortunately, there are also indicators of when measures taken by listed parties have had positive consequences for children. The Council has continued to adopt specific resolutions on children and armed conflict since 1999, each of which has included increasingly stringent provisions aimed at ensuring the protection of children. Those mandates have enabled peace processes to be implemented, resulting in the release of at least 190,000 children over the past 25 years, and have prevented numerous killings and instances of maiming, as well as acts of sexual violence against children and attacks on schools and hospitals. In that regard, it is important to stress that peace is the ultimate guarantee of children's safety, and we call on all parties to conflicts to engage in good faith in peace talks that include child protection as a key issue.

Guatemala would like to emphasize its peaceful nature as a State and strongly condemns the recruitment of children who are victims of clashes between parties to conflict and whose innocent lives are cut short. It is vital to promote the integral protection of children, as well as their social reintegration and their education in skills that will enable them to live a life free of violence and victimization. We deplore the fact that despite the efforts of the international community to prevent threats to children, abuses against children by armed groups continue to be reported. Such abuses are a grave violation of their human rights and display blatant disregard for human life. The verification in the Secretary-General's report of the abduction of Ukrainian children by Russian armed forces following the illegal, unjustified and unprovoked aggression by the Russian Federation against Ukraine is particularly alarming. The International Criminal Court has opened a case in that regard and issued arrest warrants for the abduction of Ukrainian children.

Indiscriminate attacks on hospitals and schools, the direct targeting of civilians with explosive weapons and the use of chemical weapons capable of killing thousands of children should be subject to strong sanctions by the Council. Guatemala reiterates its commitment to

ensuring and protecting the rights of children, and we therefore call on countries that have not yet done so to endorse the Safe Schools Declaration. We recognize the valuable work of the Security Council, as well as the efforts of the Special Representative, in seeking to ensure protection for children in armed conflict and respect for and compliance with international norms. We urge them to remain faithful to that commitment and to contribute to the New Agenda for Peace.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Dominican Republic.

Mr. Blanco Conde (Dominican Republic) (*spoke in Spanish*): First of all, I congratulate the United Kingdom on organizing today's debate and thank the briefers for their briefings and recommendations.

The Dominican Republic remains concerned about the continued violations and abuses against children in armed conflict. The impact of conflict on children is devastating and multifaceted. The psychological and physical trauma caused by violence, forced recruitment, sexual exploitation and forced displacement are unimaginable, and the statistics in this year's report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) are alarming. More than 27,000 grave violations have been recorded and a staggering number of killings and instances of maiming, affecting as many as 8,631 children.

Given the situation, we absolutely cannot remain indifferent. In that regard, we are grateful that the Council's Working Group on Children and Armed Conflict is conducting a field visit to Nigeria this month, its first to any country since 2019. Such engagement is essential if we are to arrive at more effective and agile solutions addressing the issue of children and armed conflict. The findings of that important Group play a fundamental role in promoting accountability and encouraging the parties to conflicts to take specific measures to prevent and end violations against children, and should be visible and accessible to States and all interested parties. However, we are deeply concerned about the fact that for the past two years the Working Group has been unable to come to conclusions on the situation in any other countries.

We fully agree with the report on the need to provide comprehensive support for children affected by armed conflict, including psychosocial assistance, education and reintegration programmes, measures that are essential to helping children and their families rebuild their lives and regain a sense of normalcy.

In Haiti, an alarming number of children — 3 million, the highest on record — require urgent humanitarian assistance. The country is dealing with extreme levels of violence that further compound problems of hunger and malnutrition in a nation that is already poor and combating a resurgence of cholera. UNICEF's representative in Haiti, Mr. Bruno Maes, underscored that to be a child in Haiti today is more dangerous and more challenging than ever, faced with unimaginable threats and adversity. It is crucial that those vulnerable children receive the necessary protection and assistance they so desperately need. Therefore, the Dominican Republic considers it very timely that this year's annual report (S/2023/363) incorporates Haiti as a situation of concern with immediate effect and will report on the violations committed against Haitian children in the next report of the Secretary-General.

In that vein, the consistent and transparent application of the criteria set out in the 2010 annual report of the Secretary-General (S/2010/181) regarding the listing and delisting of parties in the annexes is imperative. Reducing violations is not enough; we need to see a complete cessation of grave violations before a party to the conflict can be removed from the list.

The Dominican Republic has endorsed the Safe Schools Declaration, the Paris Principles and the Vancouver Principles and has also ratified the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict, demonstrating my country's commitment in that regard. We call on States that have not yet done so to endorse and ratify those instruments.

I would like to congratulate Special Representative Gamba de Potgieter and her team for the progress made in engaging with parties to conflict in countries such as Burkina Faso, Colombia, the Syrian Arab Republic and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, resulting in positive outcomes for children.

Finally, the reality of children forced to live in the midst of armed conflict around the world is a stain on our collective conscience. We must foster cooperation among States, civil society, local communities and international organizations, the United Nations and, in particular, the Security Council, and stand together as a beacon of hope by redoubling our efforts to safeguard the rights and well-being of children caught up in the crossfire of war.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Denmark.

Ms. Wegter (Denmark): On behalf of the Nordic countries — Finland, Iceland, Norway, Sweden and my own country, Denmark — I would like to thank the United Kingdom for convening this meeting and for the opportunity to reflect upon the recent report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363). Let me also thank all the briefers for their valuable insights.

We would like to focus on the following: first, the need to invest in the prevention of violations; secondly, the need for humanitarian assistance to complement local self-protection strategies; and thirdly, the value of principled direct engagement with parties to armed conflict.

First, children are particularly vulnerable to violations and abuses before, during and after conflict. We need to invest in a protective environment for children before conflict in order to reduce their vulnerability during conflict. We must invest to increase the likelihood of the successful reintegration of children associated with armed actors. We must do so in a manner that takes into account the underlying gender aspects of violations, not least those concerning sexual violence in conflict. That means investing in supporting governance structures and initiatives that protect children during conflict. One example is the Safe Schools Declaration, which facilitates protection, prevention and reintegration. Our overall investments in education, mental health and psychosocial well-being are critical enablers of child protection.

Secondly, the briefing by the Special Representative reaffirmed that too many children and communities are suffering during conflict, with little or no access to humanitarian assistance and protection. More often than not, children and their families are left to their own devices. We need to insist on humanitarian access to all children, whatever the circumstances, and make sure that our humanitarian assistance complements the self-protection strategies of those communities by supporting them in a flexible and adaptable manner.

Thirdly, international organizations can play a crucial role in protecting children. Success is often determined by sustained, principled and context-sensitive engagement directly with parties to armed conflict. The evacuation of 280 children from an orphanage in Khartoum by the International Committee of the Red Cross shows that it is possible to appeal

to belligerent parties. It speaks to the importance of direct engagement and the vital role played by such organizations. At the same time, we must hold armed parties to account and remind them of their obligations under international law, as well as promote regional human rights instruments that are so desperately needed to ensure protection and prevention.

In conclusion, we emphasize our full support for the mandate on children and armed conflict and our support for the Special Representative in her diligent work over the years. It shows that direct engagement with reference to international legal frameworks can play an important role in protecting children.

The listing of parties to armed conflict in the annexes to the Secretary-General's report is key for both prevention and accountability. We support the listing of parties in a coherent and transparent way, holding the parties to the same criteria and procedures to protect all children equally and to protect the integrity of the mandate. The fact that the Russian armed forces and affiliated armed groups have been listed gives testimony to the integrity of the Special Representative's mandate, which is to be welcomed. At the same time, it is of course deplorable that the report for the first time needs to list a permanent member of the Council.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Uruguay.

Mr. Amorín (Uruguay) (*spoke in Spanish*): First of all, Uruguay would like to thank the Permanent Mission of the United Kingdom for convening this open debate. We also in particular thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter; the Deputy Executive Director for Programmes at UNICEF, Mr. Omar Abdi; and the civil society representative for their briefings and contributions today.

Uruguay is alarmed by the findings of the Secretary-General's 2022 report on children in armed conflict (S/2023/363), which reflects an increase in violence in relation to 2021, demonstrating a disregard for international humanitarian law and international human rights law. The report highlights that, while non-State armed groups perpetrated 50 per cent of grave violations, Government forces were primarily responsible for the killing and maiming of children, as well as attacks on schools and hospitals and the denial

of humanitarian access. It is doubly worrisome that States Members of this Organization continue today to bear ultimate responsibility for such practices.

The report reflects the distressing reality faced by children in situations in 24 countries, and we regret in particular the inclusion of three new situations in 2022, namely, Ethiopia, Mozambique and Ukraine. We also deplore the 20 per cent increase in the recruitment and use of children and child abduction, as well as the 112 per cent increase in the number of attacks against schools and hospitals, particularly in Ukraine, Burkina Faso, Myanmar, Mali and Afghanistan.

Despite the grave situation of children living in armed conflict, we cannot fail to welcome the progress made in protecting children through engagement with the parties to conflict in various contexts, leading to the release of more than 12,460 children from armed groups and forces in 2022. We also welcome the progress made to protect children's rights in Burkina Faso, Colombia, the Central African Republic, the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Iraq, Israel, the State of Palestine, Nigeria, the Syrian Arab Republic, the Syrian Arab Republic and Yemen in the areas of training, prevention and accountability, by strengthening national legislation and through the adoption of action plans and other commitments.

In that regard, Uruguay would like to highlight in particular the progress made in the situation in Colombia, where August saw the suspension of air strikes against armed groups' camps in which children could have been present, in addition to Colombia's accession to the Safe Schools Declaration. We welcome both of those steps in the right direction.

Furthermore, Uruguay supports the work carried out by the United Nations and the Special Representative in her work with the parties to conflicts to put an end to and prevent violations. We understand that the work of the Office of the Special Representative should be supported without reticence and that there is a clear need for more resources to continue with the line of work in progress. That is why we insist on the need for more child protection experts on the ground to strengthen the capacities of the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism. We urge that more resources be made available for dedicated posts for this Mechanism in order to bolster its capacities on the ground.

In that regard, States must continue to work to guarantee the rights of children, who are entitled to special protections under international human rights

law, independently of their parents or guardians, support the children reintegration process as a crucial element for ensuring sustainable peace and security and break the cycles of violence. We must include regional actors and non-governmental organizations in that process so that they can play a role in the provision of sustainable political, technical and financial support in such efforts.

Member States must ensure that victims have access to legal proceedings, with all the accompanying guarantees. In our view, it is key that prevention activities be conducted by the Member States under the mechanisms established in the United Nations. In that context, it is vital that the Organization's peace forces active policies on the ground to prevent such practices.

Uruguay is no stranger to these issues. As a troop-contributing country that has an unbreakable commitment to the protection of civilians and, in particular, to the protection of children in armed conflicts, Uruguay has consistently strived to improve the training of its deployed officials. We are aware that the degree of commitment with the service of national contingents should be accompanied by training in order to achieve more effective protection of local populations, in general, and children, in particular.

To that end, implementing those commitment in order to prevent and put an end to violations against children requires focused strategies and improved practices. In that regard, in line with the agreed international instruments, in 2020 Uruguay adopted a policy for child protection for personnel deployed in United Nations peacekeeping operations, thus making my country the first in peacekeeping operations that has a specific policy for child protection in conflict situations. It is worth noting that my country received the support and collaboration of the United Kingdom, UNICEF and Keeping Children Safe for the adoption of that policy.

Since 2021, Uruguay has had a national guidebook in place for child protection instructors in peacekeeping missions. It includes chapters on training, prevention, detection and protection of victims' rights and the creation of reports and investigations to provide to personnel prior to their deployment. In line with that policy, Uruguay's national school for peacekeeping operations is certified to include in its courses the issues related to the protection of civilians and children in armed conflicts.

Uruguay once again calls on the States that have not yet done so, to adopt the applicable protocols on child protection, including the Paris Principles, the Vancouver Principles and the Safe Schools Declaration. We remain at the full disposal of the United Nations and its Member States to share its national experiences in that regard and to continue to work closely with them to make progress in this area.

The President: Let me remind all speakers to try to limit their statements to no more than three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Romania.

Mr. Feruță (Romania): In addition to the statement delivered by the observer of the European Union, I would like to add a few points.

I also join others in thanking the briefers for their sober reports on the situation of children in armed conflicts around the world.

It is indeed appalling to witness such a high number of violations affecting so many children, but also to see the disregard for international humanitarian law and international human rights law. The report of Secretary-General Guterres (S/2023/363) points to a massive failure in protecting one of the most vulnerable categories. It is worrisome that perpetrators are blatantly disregarding international humanitarian law and are rewarded with impunity.

The inclusion of the Russian armed forces as responsible for committing grave violations against children in the Secretary-General's latest report on children and armed conflict is a step towards ensuring the accountability of the perpetrators.

Almost 500 days since the start of Russia's unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression in Ukraine, ending the climate of impunity is the way forward to prevent and respond to the grave violations against children in armed conflict. The States Members of the United Nations also need to hear and know more about the fate of the 700,000 children that the Russian authorities admit taking from Ukraine.

Romania remains committed to advancing and protecting children's rights, including for the prevention and response to grave violations during armed conflicts. The best interests of the child is the core principle of our legislation, policies and actions. We have applied it, together with UNICEF, in relation to the refugee children from Ukraine.

My Government has been making continued efforts to implement all Security Council resolutions related to today's topic. I echo the need for efforts to combat abuse and sexual exploitation, to ensure the protection of civilians and children in armed conflicts and to improve the training process for our armed forces.

My country also supports States affected by landmines, whose victims are — too often — children, through our participation in international United Nations peacekeeping missions.

Romania pays special attention to family reunification as a precondition for a child to grow up and develop harmoniously. Our national legislation ensures the protection of child refugees and the protection of children during armed conflict, as well as the responsible of public authorities in that regard. Children are our future, and they must always be protected. Part of their future is also the right to education. We join the call on Member States to endorse the Safe Schools Declaration.

Finally, we would like to reaffirm our full support for the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict and for UNICEF on the protection of children and respect for international law. We acknowledge that the children and armed conflict mandate in the United Nations peace and security architecture is an essential tool for their protection.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Canada.

Mr. Black (Canada): I have the honour of delivering this statement on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict. We welcome today's open debate, convened by the United Kingdom, and thank today's briefers.

We once again encourage the Security Council to regularly include children and youth briefers in its work and call for the safe and meaningful inclusion and participation of children and youth in all matters of peace and security.

The Group of Friends welcomes the Secretary-General's annual report (S/2023/363), while expressing our serious concern with the scale and scope of the 27,180 grave violations that affected 18,890 children. The trends presented in the report are disturbing and must be reversed.

We call upon all parties to armed conflict to fully comply with their obligations under international humanitarian, human rights and refugee law and to act to prevent and end grave violations against children. To that end, we strongly encourage all parties to armed conflict to sign and implement action plans and other concrete, time-bound measures to enhance the protection of children in armed conflict.

We call for full accountability for grave violations through national and international justice mechanisms, such as the International Criminal Court. True justice also involves reparations and access to gender- and age-sensitive comprehensive specialized services, including medical, mental health and psychosocial support and sexual and reproductive health-care services, as well as legal and livelihood support, to survivors of grave violations.

We encourage all States Members of the United Nations to accede to the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict and to consider endorsing and implementing practical child protection instruments, such as the Safe Schools Declaration, the Paris Principles and Commitments and the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers.

We call for adequate resourcing for child protection specialists and activities and urge support to the full implementation of child protection mandates by United Nations peace operations.

The Group of Friends expresses its appreciation for the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, UNICEF and all child-protection actors from the United Nations and civil society.

The children and armed conflict architecture that the Council established is increasingly challenged to address the sharp increase both in grave violations against children and the number of situations in which they are occurring. We are particularly concerned with the report's finding that Government forces are now the main perpetrators of the killing and maiming of children, attacks on schools and hospitals and denial of humanitarian assistance. In that regard, we note new listing decisions this year.

The plight of children in armed conflict remains dire and necessitates the full and effective use of all tools at our disposal to prevent and end grave violations

against children. We reiterate the importance of the independence, impartiality and credibility of the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism and the listing mechanism, as contained in the Secretary-General's annual reports on children and armed conflict.

We note that Haiti and the Niger are designated in the report as situations of concern with immediate effect. We also note the listing decisions in the annexes, as well as the criteria for those decisions.

We reiterate our call for the information presented in the Secretary-General's annual reports, as collected and verified by the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism, to be reflected in the annexes of the report in an accurate and timely manner. And we recall the importance of the Secretary-General utilizing clear criteria and procedures for listing and delisting parties to armed conflict deemed responsible for committing grave violations across all situations contained in the report.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of New Zealand.

Ms. Schwalger (New Zealand): I deliver this statement on behalf of Canada, Australia and my own country, New Zealand (CANZ).

I thank the Special Representative and her Office for their tireless work.

It is shocking to CANZ, as it should be to all of us, that 27,180 verified grave violations against children occurred in 2022. In one year alone, 18,890 children around the world were recruited and used in conflict. Unfortunately, these figures probably represent only a small fraction of the number of actual victims around the world. A 112 per cent increase in the number of attacks on schools and hospitals is simply unacceptable. It represents immense suffering for the children affected, their families and their communities.

The fundamental measures that protect all civilians, including children, involve respecting international humanitarian and human rights law. The worsening statistics in this year's report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) underline a serious disregard, especially by Government forces, of international humanitarian and human rights legal obligations, which is a trend which we must reverse. CANZ strongly condemns all grave violations committed against children by any State or party, and in any conflict.

CANZ calls for Russian armed forces and affiliated armed groups and their leadership to be held accountable for the grave violations they have committed against children during their ongoing war of aggression. The killing and maiming of more than 1,386 Ukrainian children in 2022 are devastating. CANZ recalls guidance of the Secretary-General on contacts with persons who are the subject of arrest warrants or summonses issued by the International Criminal Court (ICC).

The recruitment and use of children in Syria is staggering. Some 1,696 children have been deprived of a childhood; instead, they are being recruited by an array of State and non-State actors and used in combat. No childhood should be spent fighting.

CANZ condemns the high numbers of verified cases of rape and sexual violence. These are particularly concerning, given the consistent underreporting of this grave violation. This demonstrates the use of sexual and gender-based violence as a weapon of war.

The denial of humanitarian access, including in Yemen, Mali and Myanmar, is another deeply worrisome trend. We call on all parties to allow and facilitate safe, timely and unimpeded humanitarian access. To this end, CANZ underscores the Special Representative of the Secretary-General's request that the Taliban immediately revoke their ban on women working for non-governmental organizations and the United Nations in Afghanistan.

The 112 per cent increase in attacks on schools and hospitals, including the 66 verified attacks committed by the Myanmar armed forces, along with unlawful abductions, adds to an already dire picture. The protection international humanitarian law provides for civilian persons and civilian objects must be respected in all situations. In addition to our commitment to international humanitarian law, the three CANZ members have all endorsed the Safe Schools Declaration.

CANZ welcomes the inclusion of Haiti and the Niger as situations of concern, given the number of violations reported.

While the situation put forward in this year's report is alarming, we wish to acknowledge the critical positive steps taken to protect and reintegrate children in the last year. We welcome the signing of action plans — first, by the Government of Iraq in that

country, and secondly, by the Houthis in Yemen. We also welcome commitments and developments in other countries with regard to prevention, accountability, national legislation, training and capacity-building.

Tackling impunity, through prompt investigation and, where appropriate, prosecution for war crimes, genocide and crimes against humanity, is needed to strengthen our response to grave violations against children. We implore States to cooperate with international justice mechanisms, including the ICC.

CANZ encourages the Security Council to ensure that child protection tasks and capabilities are included in all relevant peacekeeping and special political mission mandates, and that these are adequately maintained through transitions or during reconfigurations.

More child protection expertise is needed to reinforce the children and armed conflict Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism's capacities. The demands on the system are greater than ever before. All United Nations actors must dedicate resources for the Mechanism in situations on the children and armed conflict agenda, and the international community must do better in supporting United Nations country teams.

CANZ is proud to underscore our support for both the Paris Principles and the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers. We call upon countries that have not yet done so to endorse these important commitments. We remain a strong supporter of the children and armed conflict mandate, and we wish, like others, to work together to protect our children — who are our future — from the scourge of war.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Chile.

Mr. Vidal (Chile) (*spoke in Spanish*): Chile thanks the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate. We take note of the briefings and statements heard today. We of course wish the United Kingdom every success as it presides over the Security Council this month.

Chile aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends on Children in Armed Conflict earlier.

There is no doubt that the international community must increase its efforts to safeguard children in armed conflict. This means providing children with security,

education, rehabilitation and support networks. Our position is clear and unequivocal on this issue. Protecting children and their rights is a moral imperative because children represent the most valuable element of the future of humankind.

Precisely for that reason, Chile has ratified most of the international treaties that seek to protect children in conflict situations. In the same vein, we are committed to the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers. We favour a preventive approach to conflict. In this regard, we believe that the best way to prevent the recruitment of children is to foster a culture of peace, as well as democratic, inclusive and resilient societies, in order to avoid segregation and social marginalization.

In the long term, children in conflict must be protected from the beginning to the end of the cycle of violence, with a view to reaching full and systemic reintegration. In line with this, we value General Assembly resolutions 64/290, of 2010, entitled “The right to education in emergency situations”, and 74/275, entitled “International Day to Protect Education from Attack”, of 2020. We have also joined the Safe Schools Declaration, which was adopted in Oslo in May 2015.

We welcome the comprehensive report of the Secretary-General on this subject (S/2023/363) and underline the concern expressed on the role of Government entities as perpetrators of violations, especially the targeting of schools and hospitals. The recruitment and use of children by armed groups is unacceptable. We deeply regret the serious situation of violations against children’s rights in armed conflicts in several countries; in fact, three new ones were added to the list in the reporting period. We join the Secretary-General’s call to Member States to provide special protection and care for children and adolescents, as well as support for their reintegration. With regard to the report’s recommendations, Chile shares the views expressed by the Secretary-General.

Finally, and as has been our practice, we will continue to cooperate with the United Nations to prevent grave violations against children and will participate in any ad hoc groups that may be created in that regard.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Spain.

Mr. Gutiérrez Segú Berdullas (Spain) (*spoke in Spanish*): Spain aligns itself with the statement made

on behalf of the European Union, and that delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

This agenda is a priority for my country in the context of promoting respect for international humanitarian law and the protection of civilians. The protection of all children in armed conflicts is one of the main lines of action in the strategy for humanitarian diplomacy that Spain adopted in January.

We thank the Secretary-General for his report (S/2023/363), as well as Special Representative Virginia Gamba de Potgieter and her Office for their tireless work, which we will continue to support. We will also continue our active cooperation with UNICEF.

We are concerned about the situation described in the report, especially the increase in violence against children in armed conflicts in the past year. The data, such as the 122 per cent increase in attacks against schools and hospitals, are alarming and unacceptable. The figures remind us of the vulnerability of children in conflict situations and the need to ensure humanitarian access.

We are also concerned about the situation in Ukraine, where Russia’s aggression continues to hit schools, hospitals and other civilian infrastructure, as well as claim the lives of children. The evidence of the forced deportation of thousands of Ukrainian minors is also extremely grave, constituting war crimes. We all have a responsibility to apply international law with the utmost rigour and to hold accountable those who violate it.

Spain is working to ensure the right to education in conflict situations. We will continue, through our establishment of the Giga Technology Centre in Barcelona, our financial commitment to the Giga Initiative aimed at closing the digital divide in education by 2030 by connecting all schools around the world to the Internet, including those in countries in conflict.

My country is fully committed to the implementation of the Safe Schools Declaration, as well as the Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas. In that regard, we urge countries that have not signed those texts to do so without delay.

We are also pursuing our commitment to ensuring children’s right to health and to implementing resolution 2286 (2016), on the protection of health care in conflict, of which we were a co-sponsor.

Women and girls continue to be especially vulnerable to sexual violence in conflict. It is therefore essential to support preventive approaches and women's effective participation in decision-making, thereby strengthening the women and peace and security agenda.

It is essential for peace operations to improve and expand child protection mandates. The Security Council can enhance protection mandates, including by appointing protection advisers and expert teams, and has Spain's support in that regard.

On 1 July, we assumed the six-month presidency of the Council of the European Union. During these months, we will raise awareness on humanitarian issues, including the protection of civilians and children in armed conflict.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Kuwait.

Mr. Mohammad (Kuwait) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to take this opportunity to warmly congratulate you, Mr. President, on the assumption of your friendly country, the United Kingdom, of the presidency of the Security Council for this month, and I wish you every success. I also thank you for convening this important open debate on children and armed conflict and for preparing the concept note (S/2023/470, annex) for this meeting. I would also like to thank the briefers for their valuable remarks earlier today.

As we meet today, we have before us the annual report of the Secretary-General, António Guterres, on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). What is stated therein should shock our collective conscience. The information and figures included in the report are alarming and unfortunate, and they reflect the disconnect we are seeing at the United Nations in general and in the Security Council in particular. As we speak in the halls of the United Nations, and specifically here in the Council Chamber, about the protection of civilians in armed conflicts and the importance of complying with international humanitarian law and international human rights law, the report reveals a picture on the ground that is completely different from what we are calling for in the halls of the United Nations.

The report shows how children have become targets on the front lines in armed conflicts, indicating that the United Nations has verified more than 27,000 grave violations against children in armed conflicts, including

a range of violations such as the killing and maiming of children, the recruitment or use of children by armed forces and groups, attacks on schools or hospitals, sexual violence, the abduction of children and the denial of humanitarian access to children. Conflicts around the world rob children — who are the most vulnerable group in armed conflicts — of their innocence and their inherent right to life, decent living, survival and development. In the face of the horrific information in the report, the international community cannot stand idly by and allow a situation in which innocent children live in terror and are subjected to violence and harm. Children should live in an environment that guarantees their protection and a sense of safety.

When we speak about children and armed conflict, we are compelled, time and again, to address the suffering of the defenceless Palestinian people and their children. In that regard, the State of Kuwait reaffirms its condemnation in the strongest terms of the violations by Israel, the occupying Power, against the Palestinian people and their children. Those violations have been committed before the eyes of the international community for decades. The Israeli occupation forces continue to perpetrate heinous crimes against the Palestinian people, most recently in the city of Jenin, which led to the martyrdom and injury of many Palestinians, including children. The children of Palestine have been suffering grave violations over many years, not limited only to killings, maiming and detentions, but also the destruction of educational, health and other basic facilities, displacing them and their families and leading to the deterioration of the humanitarian and living conditions in their communities.

In that regard, we renew our call on the Council to shoulder its political, legal and humanitarian responsibilities to stop the repeated attacks by the Israeli occupation forces against the brotherly Palestinian people and their children, and to work to provide them with international protection, while also stressing the need to hold accountable those responsible for the crimes committed against the Palestinian people. We once again ask the Council: how much longer will the Council continue to apply double standards when dealing with the Palestinian people and their just cause? How much longer will the Council allow Israel, the occupying Power, to continue its actions, practices and violations as if it is above the law? How much longer will the Council remain silent as the Palestinian

people — including their children — are denied their legitimate rights, as if the rules and provisions of international law do not apply to the rights of the Palestinian people? The inability of the international community to address the Palestinian question and hold Israel, the occupying Power, accountable remains the greatest failure in the history of the United Nations in general and the Security Council in particular. It represents a disgrace to humankind.

In conclusion, expressing our outrage over the atrocities committed against children in armed conflicts around the world is not enough. It is time to end violence against children. It is time to hold the perpetrators of crimes against children accountable. It is time to end conflicts, achieve sustainable peace, implement the Security Council's resolutions and support the efforts of the United Nations to protect children and provide basic services, relief and humanitarian assistance without discrimination or impediments. If we can make progress in implementing such measures we will help to protect the world from losing yet another generation of innocent children to war and conflict. The State of Kuwait stresses that strengthening international efforts is more crucial than ever in addressing all forms of grave violations against children in armed conflict in order to provide them with effective protection, guarantee their legitimate rights, prevent further crimes against them and hold those responsible for such violations accountable.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Qatar.

Mr. Al-Maawda (Qatar) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, Mr. President, I would like to offer our congratulations to the United Kingdom on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month and our thanks for convening this important debate. We are also grateful to Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, for her comprehensive briefing, and to the other briefers for their statements.

We align ourselves with the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

The discussion today provides an important opportunity to consider the findings of the Secretary-General's annual report (S/2023/363) on children and armed conflict. The report highlights the sad reality and the negative impact of conflicts and crises on children's

lives, and notes the increase in the number of children affected by grave violations in 2022, including through damage to schools and hospitals and deprivation of education and health services. We commend the efforts to highlight and include such violations in the report. In the light of the huge numbers of violations and their disastrous consequences for human rights, our efforts to address them must be commensurate with their gravity and impact on international peace and security. In the first place, we must step up efforts to protect children at all stages of conflict and ensure respect for international humanitarian law and international human rights law. In our view, strengthening accountability mechanisms is one of the crucial factors in ending impunity. It is equally important to ensure that children in conflict situations receive adequate protection and attention.

We firmly believe that armed conflict should not interfere with the right to education. Failing to guarantee children's right to education risks undermining human rights and sustainable development, especially in societies that are suffering from conflict. The State of Qatar is well known as a major contributor to support for quality education worldwide. We have prioritized protecting and strengthening the right to education, particularly in emergency situations, within the framework of our international emergency development and relief programmes. In that regard, I would like to point out that Qatar launched an initiative in the educational arena when we spearheaded international efforts around the adoption of General Assembly resolution 74/275, which proclaimed 9 September as the International Day to Protect Education from Attack. Following its adoption, Qatar's Education Above All Foundation launched TRACE, the Track Attacks on Education data portal, which collects data related to attacks on educational institutions and aims to identify their perpetrators. The Foundation's programmes have helped provide quality education for millions of children all over the world.

We commend the important role and efforts of the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict and UNICEF. I want to point out that in the period from 2018 to 2023, the State of Qatar has contributed \$2.5 million to the Office of the Special Representative with a view to strengthening its role and its ability to implement its crucial mandate. We also supported the operationalization of the Analysis and Outreach Hub in Doha, which we opened in June 2022 and which will

work to improve institutional knowledge on current and future efforts for the protection of children, with a focus on their reintegration, and to implement the Practical Guidance for Mediators to Protect Children in Situations of Armed Conflict.

In conclusion, ensuring full respect for children's human rights and creating an environment conducive to children's secure education contribute to building stable, safe and prosperous societies. We reiterate the State of Qatar's commitment to supporting all efforts aimed at protecting children in armed conflict and at preventing such conflict.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of San Marino.

Mr. Beleffi (San Marino): I would like to thank the delegation of the United Kingdom for convening this important meeting, the Secretary-General for his annual report (S/2023/363) and the briefers for their presentations.

San Marino aligns itself with the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict and with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union.

We firmly support the children and armed conflict agenda and call on all armed forces and armed groups listed in the report's annexes to engage constructively with the United Nations to develop and implement action plans to end and prevent grave violations against children. San Marino is particularly worried about the high number of grave violations against children described this year in the Secretary-General's report. Armed conflict continues to devastate children's lives and compromise their fundamental rights. The report shows a disturbing increase in attacks on schools and hospitals, which is unacceptable. San Marino firmly condemns attacks on schools and hospitals, as well as their use for military purposes. Children's right to health care and education are fundamental and should always be preserved.

We reiterate our support for the Safe Schools Declaration. Educational facilities should be a safe place for all children, students and teachers. Education is a powerful tool for peace and should therefore be supported and respected. San Marino is also very concerned about the substantial increase in the recruitment and use of child soldiers. We call on all Member States to ratify the Optional Protocol

to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict. We also encourage all parties to support other important tools such as the Paris Principles and Commitments and the Vancouver Principles.

Civilians and civilian infrastructure must be respected. San Marino is extremely concerned about the disregard we are seeing for international humanitarian law. We call on all parties to strictly abide by international humanitarian and human rights law. Furthermore, the use of explosive weapons in populated areas has resulted in increases in the numbers of deaths, physical injuries and trauma among civilians, including children, who subsequently find themselves unable to return to their daily lives even after a conflict ends. San Marino is deeply concerned in that regard, and we therefore immediately endorsed the recently adopted Political Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas and encourage all States to do the same and to abide by its commitments.

We reiterate the importance of accountability for all grave violations against children and of refusing to accept impunity for the perpetrators of such violations. The international community has the duty not only to stop and prevent those violations, but also to assist child victims and work for their reintegration. The Government of San Marino appreciates the work of national non-governmental organizations in their efforts to prevent the use of child soldiers and for the promotion of children's rights.

I would like to express San Marino's unwavering support for the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict and of her Office. We welcome the new action plans and commitments that have been signed or that are in progress. No child should ever live the horror of war. That should not be forgotten. Ultimately, children are the root of peace, and we should therefore invest in them, their safety and their future.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Estonia.

Mr. Tammsaar (Estonia): I have the honour to speak on behalf of the three Baltic countries — Latvia, Lithuania and, my own country, Estonia.

I thank you, Mr. President, for convening today's Security Council open debate, and I thank the briefers for their briefings.

Every year, the report on children and armed conflict provides us with a horrific overview of the violations committed against children around the globe. Sadly, this year's report (S/2023/363) is no exception, as we are once again witnessing an overall increase in violence against children, as exemplified by more than 27,000 verified cases of grave violations committed in ongoing protracted conflicts — be it in the Lake Chad basin and the Democratic Republic of the Congo, or in the Secretary-General's designated new situations of concern in Haiti and the Niger. Unfortunately, there is also an increase in the number of actors listed as parties committing grave violations against children.

The most significant addition to the list of grave violations is the Russian Federation. It is beyond shameful that a Member State whose primary responsibility is to maintain peace and security in the world, a member that lectures us here in the Council about what is right and what is wrong, has itself committed 878 verified appalling cases of grave violations against children in Ukraine. The actual number is deemed to be much higher. Besides, that number does not include the thousands of children abducted or illegally deported from occupied Ukrainian territories to Russia.

According to the report, the armed forces of a permanent member of the Security Council do not only use children as human shields and attack schools where they are studying, but the Russian military, mercenaries and security forces also torture, abduct, rape and kill children on a daily basis during the military aggression, led by a criminal wanted by the International Criminal Court.

We commend the Special Representative's efforts to agree and implement the joint prevention plan with Ukraine and the joint action plan with the aggressor State, Russia. Yet Russia's commitment is utterly unconvincing. On the day of the release of the report alone, which recognizes Russia's engagement with the Special Representative on the use of explosive weapons with wide-area impact, three children were killed, among many civilians, by a Russian targeted ballistic missile strike against a restaurant in Kramatorsk.

Therefore, a question should be posed. Does Russia care about those children who lost their lives? I am afraid the honest answer is "absolutely not". And maybe

that is the reason that the report remains rather vague on the practical measures agreed with the Russian Federation, while mentioning the numerous initiatives and steps Ukraine has implemented. The only thing that matters for Russian leadership, which, in spite of the internal power struggle, remains obsessed with Ukraine and with restoring Russia's former imperial grandeur, is to erase a sovereign Ukraine from the map and exterminate the Ukrainian nation at any cost. Targeting children is an ugly but integral part of that inhuman plan.

In conclusion, armed conflicts, into which children are involuntarily drawn, scar their lives forever and further fuel the cycle of violence. Although the childhood of targeted children cannot be salvaged, the perpetrators of those heinous actions must always be held fully accountable. The only thing left for me to say is to reassure those present in the Chamber that we in the Baltic States will continue to support the Office of the Special Representative, UNICEF and other child protection actors in their efforts to protect the rights of children around the globe.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Bulgaria.

Ms. Stoeva (Bulgaria): Bulgaria aligns itself with the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

I would like to express my appreciation to the United Kingdom for organizing this year's open debate on children and armed conflict. Bulgaria would also like to thank today's briefers for their remarks — Special Representative of the Secretary-General Virginia Gamba de Potgieter and UNICEF Deputy Executive Director for Programmes Omar Abdi — and especially Ms. Violeta for her both sobering and inspiring story. Allow me to reiterate Bulgaria's robust support for the children and armed conflict mandate.

The recent report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) is a striking reminder of the urgency of the issue at hand. Alarming, the overall number of children affected by armed conflict has increased since 2021. Considering the difficult access and strict verification standards, the 27,180 children affected by grave violations in 2022 may well be only the tip of the iceberg.

We are particularly concerned about the Niger and Haiti, both newly designated as situations of concern. Bulgaria supports the signing of action plans, such as the most recent one with the Houthis in Yemen in 2022, and we welcome progress in engaging with parties to protect children in conflicts in Africa, South America, the Middle East and Eastern Europe.

Bulgaria has been vocal about the Russian Federation's war of aggression, including its impact on children. The Group of Friends of Children and the Sustainable Development Goals, co-chaired by Bulgaria, issued two joint statements on that subject. The listing of Russia in annex II to the report, highlighting parties that commit grave violations affecting children, is yet additional proof of the moral bankruptcy of the Kremlin, which has led a permanent member of the Council to find itself on the same list as non-State armed groups, including terrorists. Bulgaria reiterates its call on the Russian Federation to immediately cease its aggression and withdraw from the territory of Ukraine within its internationally recognized borders.

We urge all parties to adopt and implement handover protocols for children encountered or detained during military operations to civilian child protection actors, refrain from using schools and hospitals for military purposes and endorse the Safe Schools Declaration. We should all support the Vancouver Principles, ratify the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict and implement the Paris Principles. We also urge parties to refrain from using explosive weapons in populated areas and to endorse the political declaration on that subject.

I would like to reaffirm Bulgaria's commitment to the protection and promotion of the rights of the child in armed conflict and highlight the importance of the continuation of education in areas of armed conflict. Education is central to preventing the recruitment and use of children by armed forces and groups.

Last but not least, allow me to pay tribute to all those working in the field for the protection and promotion of the rights of the child in the context of armed conflict. Oftentimes, they are the only chance for children in armed conflict. Their work is invaluable, and they do make a difference.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative Türkiye.

Mrs. Özgür (Türkiye): The Secretary-General's report (S/2023/363) highlights the worsening global trend for children in armed conflict. The heavy toll on children as a result of the war in Ukraine is concerning. Children deserve more and special attention as one of the most fragile groups. That is why Türkiye has prioritized children in its humanitarian assistance to Ukraine.

Since March 2022, we have hosted more than 1,000 Ukrainian orphans and 500 caregivers in Türkiye. We took necessary measures to meet their accommodation, care, health and education needs in our country. We also brought together the Russian and Ukrainian ombudspersons in Ankara in January. They discussed humanitarian issues, including the return of children and family reunification. We will continue our efforts in that regard.

In Iraq, decades of war, authoritarian rule, ethnic and sectarian violence and infighting have had adverse effects on children. By exploiting the security vacuum, terrorist organizations — mainly Da'esh and the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK) — have mobilized every possible means to realize their inhumane and destructive agendas in that country. As widely reported by members of the Yazidi community, the PKK/People's Protection Units (YPG) terrorist organization has kidnapped hundreds of Yazidi children from the Sinjar and Al-Hol camps in Syria and subjected them to ideological brainwashing for recruitment purposes since 2015. Indeed, the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) shows that the PKK terrorist organization is primarily responsible for the recruitment and use of children in Iraq. Likewise, the PKK-Democratic Union Party (PYD)-Syrian Democratic Forces (SDF) terrorist organization once again tops the list for the recruitment and use of children in Syria, in addition to the horrendous numbers of girls and boys that it has killed or maimed. Moreover, it is the PKK-PYD-SDF that has been primarily responsible for the military use of schools and hospitals in Syria, as well as the abduction of children.

However, we are surprised by the report's random approach in its references to the PKK terrorist organization in Syria. The truth is that the so-called SDF, the Internal Security Forces, the PYD, the YPG and the Women's Protection Units are all elements of the same terrorist organization — the PKK. The separatist terminology — “under the authority of the autonomous administration of northern and eastern Syria” — used

in complete disregard for the territorial integrity of a United Nations Member State, also refers to the very same terrorist organization. The PKK perpetrated more than 530 attacks in Syria last year alone, killing and maiming hundreds of civilians, including children. It has also continued to forcibly impose its separatist curriculum on schools in the areas that it controls in Syria and to dismiss, arrest and mistreat teachers who oppose its oppression. My Government continues to share with the United Nations the relevant data and evidence of violations inflicted on children in Syria by the PKK-PYD-SDF.

I also want to put on record my country's position with regard to the incorrect references in the report to Türkiye's counter-terrorism operations in Syria and Iraq. Those operations are conducted as part of Türkiye's inherent right to self-defence, in line with Article 51 of the Charter of the United Nations and in full compliance with international law and international humanitarian law. They target terrorists exclusively, and the utmost attention and care is taken to avoid any harm to civilians and civilian infrastructure. Türkiye supports the efforts of the United Nations in addressing the situation of children in armed conflict and will continue to work closely with the United Nations system, including the Office of the Special Representative, to that end.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Armenia.

Mr. Margaryan (Armenia): We thank the presidency of the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate on the theme of children and armed conflict. We appreciate the comprehensive presentations by the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter; the Deputy Executive Director for Programmes at UNICEF, Mr. Omar Abdi; and the civil-society briefer.

Armenia emphasizes the critical importance of upholding the goals, objectives and principles enshrined in the Safe Schools Declaration and the Paris and Vancouver Principles with the aim of promoting and protecting the rights of all children, especially those in conflict-affected areas, and of preventing grave violations of children's rights. The Secretary-General's report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363) reveals the growing number of challenges faced by children as multidimensional conflicts, including across regions, continued to have an adverse impact on the lives of civilians during the reporting period of 2022.

It demonstrates that monitoring and verifying grave violations remain extremely challenging, including owing to constraints on access, leading to the underreporting of such violations. Underreporting is a major challenge that can lead to bias and inadequate responses and enable the perpetration of further violations, including in my own region.

In September 2022, Azerbaijan conducted an armed attack on Armenia's territorial integrity, exposing a number of villages and towns deep inside Armenia to massive shelling by heavy artillery and uncrewed aerial vehicles. Azerbaijan's premeditated criminal actions violated the right to education of 25,000 children displaced from Gegharkunik, Vayots Dzor and Syunik provinces. Since 12 December 2022 the civilian population in Nagorno-Karabakh has fallen victim to an inhumane blockade by Azerbaijan that has severely affected the rights and livelihoods of the most vulnerable — children. As we speak, the ongoing blockade of the Lachin corridor, in violation of the existing legal obligations and an order from the International Court of Justice, continues to endanger the lives of innocent people in Nagorno-Karabakh.

For almost seven months now, families with children have been suffering from critical shortages of essential goods, including food, fuel and medical supplies. The humanitarian situation has been further exacerbated by the complete disruption of its gas and electricity supplies. Owing to weather conditions, 118 schools have had to suspend their activities, depriving 20,000 children of their right to education. That includes early education, with preschools no longer operational due to food insecurity, affecting more than 6,800 children. The provision of health services has been severely disrupted, with an acute lack of antibiotics and other types of medication leaving children susceptible to otherwise easily treatable diseases, while hundreds of newborns are experiencing nutritional problems exacerbated by an ongoing shortage of infant formula.

On 22 February, the International Court of Justice issued an order requiring Azerbaijan to take provisional measures

“at its disposal to ensure unimpeded movement of persons, vehicles and cargo along the Lachin corridor in both directions.”

So far Azerbaijan has failed to ensure compliance with the Court's legally binding order of the Court. Azerbaijan's denial of safe and unimpeded

humanitarian access for United Nations agencies to Nagorno-Karabakh undermines the comprehensive assessment of the humanitarian, protection and early-recovery needs and the human rights situation of the population to ensure the protection of the rights of children and their access to inclusive and quality education, health care and social services.

As the leading United Nations advocate for the protection of children affected by armed conflict, the Special Representative of the Secretary-General has a central role to play in raising awareness of the need to increase efforts to protect children whose inalienable rights are under brutal attack. The intentional disruption of the Lachin corridor, which has left 30,000 children and their families besieged, constitutes a violation of massive scope and gravity. We call on the Special Representative to use her important mandate to monitor the situation and to make efforts to ensure humanitarian access in order to avoid any further deterioration of the conditions affecting the lives of the children in Nagorno-Karabakh.

The United Nations and its humanitarian arm, the Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs, as well as the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict and the Council itself, have a particular responsibility to prevent grave violations and safeguard the physical security of children, whose rights and safety must be respected and protected at all times in all parts of the world, including Nagorno-Karabakh.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of the Philippines.

Mrs. Lora-Santos (Philippines): The Philippines thanks the delegation of the United Kingdom for holding this open debate and the briefers for their informative presentations.

The Philippines is committed to protecting children and fulfilling all its obligations under the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its Optional Protocols, including their right not to know the horrors of war. We take a whole-of-Government approach to issues relating to children and armed conflict and to addressing grave violations committed against children. We would like to point to the finding in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) that grave violations against children in the Philippines decreased by 38 per cent in 2022. The Government is committed to implementing

its law on children in situations of armed conflict across the relevant national agencies, local governments and civil society, down to the grass-roots level.

Civil-society organizations, non-governmental organizations and indigenous communities have a meaningful role to play in raising awareness of child-protection issues and particularly in preventing the recruitment of child combatants. The Council on the Welfare of Children is the focal inter-agency body that coordinates the enforcement and implementation of all laws on children, ensuring a child-friendly and -sensitive society where every child enjoys their rights. It promptly intervenes in cases of children rescued from armed rebel groups and reintegrates them into their families and communities, in collaboration with the Department of Social Welfare and Development.

In June 2021, the Government signed the strategic plan to prevent and respond to grave child right violations in situations of armed conflict. The Philippine National Police issued a child protection policy that incorporates the provisions of the law on children in situations of armed conflict and its handling protocol. More than 3,000 child protection actors were trained on the laws and policies on child protection. The children and armed conflict agenda was also incorporated in the Bangsamoro Children's Code in the Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao.

Children are zones of peace. That is a central principle in our law on children in situations of armed conflict. It means that everyone is required to preserve the peaceful integrity of children, exemplify mutual respect and non-violent behaviour in the presence of children and resolve all armed conflicts that cause damage to children. At all times, even during armed conflict, the human rights and best interests of children must be the primary consideration in any decision. That entails not only the prohibition of attacks on schools or the use of schools for military purposes, but also the creation and facilitation of alternative ways of delivering education services to children during situations of armed conflict.

To protect learners and schools from conflict or its effects, we have the National Policy Framework on Learners and Schools as Zones of Peace. That framework serves as a guide to the defence and education sectors for the creation of safe, inclusive and conflict-sensitive learning environments for children. No attacks on schools are tolerated.

Having the law on children in situations of armed conflict and its implementing protocols, regulations and frameworks streamline the coordination of the efforts of all agencies concerned in order to ensure the safety of children. Positive outcomes can be maximized and achieved earlier with the involvement of civil society, non-governmental organizations, communities and families. We cannot overemphasize the importance of a whole-of-society approach in protecting children from armed conflict, as well as in preventing armed conflict and building peace, in general.

The President: We are halfway through the list for this afternoon, so I encourage all speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes in order to allow us to finish in good time.

I now give the floor to the representative of Israel.

Mr. Miller (Israel): I thank you, Mr. President, for convening this important meeting, and I thank the briefers for their statements earlier today.

The safety and well-being of children, as well as their safety and protection, is a matter of the utmost importance for Israel. That is why we commend the United Nations for also putting the protection of children at the forefront. Any measure taken to protect children in armed conflict is a measure that Israel stands by.

Nevertheless, after reading the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/363), it seems that, when it comes to Israel, the United Nations has once again opted to advance a politicized agenda, rather than focus on those truly responsible for the danger, maiming and deaths of children. The report demonizes Israel despite the fact that when it comes to protecting the lives of the innocent, especially children, Israel goes above and beyond the letter of the law in order to do so.

Video footage of Israel aborting strikes on terrorists due to the proximity of children and other civilians are widely circulated. Several such videos were publicized throughout Operation Shield and Arrow in Gaza, in May, and such extensive measures are taken during every Israeli defensive operation. The Israel Defense Forces are one of the most moral militaries in the world, and no one-sided politicized report will prove otherwise. Yet sadly, Israel's iron-clad moral compass is interpreted as weakness by our enemies — a weakness that they constantly aim to exploit.

Those that seek Israel's destruction know that Israel will never target children or deliberately put innocent's in harm's way — not now, not ever — while they weaponize this ethical integrity in their jihad war against us. They turn mosques into arms caches, as we saw just two days ago in Jenin. They utilize hospitals as rocket launchpads. They use schools and even United Nations Relief and Works Agency for Palestine Refugees in the Near East (UNRWA) schools as cover for terror tunnels. We know that the United Nations knows that, yet it was hardly even mentioned in the report.

Imagine what would have happened if a terror tunnel that was discovered underneath an UNRWA school in Gaza last November had collapsed, or if explosives stored in it had detonated while Palestinian children were playing in the yard above. Palestinian children deserve to grow up in safety, but sadly the *modus operandi* of their leadership is to use them as human shields. They do that because they know that targeting innocence is a red line that Israel does not and will not cross. The fact that terrorists understand and exploit that, but United Nations entities refuse to condemn or, at the very least, address it is truly incomprehensible.

One reaps what one sows. When Palestine leaders invest extensive resources and funding into furthering incitement and hatred, it is no surprise that they are raising a generation of youth driven by violence. The number of minors carrying out terror attacks is growing exponentially. Palestinian teens set out to murder Israelis because they see the so-called honour such attacks would bring them and the payments through the Palestinian Authority's "pay-for-slay" programme that the families receive for their crimes. That is not discussed in the report.

Hamas and Palestinian Islamic Jihad sponsor annual summer camps for Gazan youths to become indoctrinated to murder Israelis. That is something that those terror organizations take great pride in and publicize on a wide scale, yet they are similarly not mentioned once in the report. In fact, Hamas — the designated terror organization that holds the civilians of Gaza hostage, recruits children, hides behind them and uses them as human shields — is only mentioned once in the report, and in a positive light. Again, this is truly incomprehensible.

Children should be in schools to further their education, not incited to hatred. Children should be encouraged to throw balls, not rocks. Children should

be given toys to play with, not weapons. It is tragic that Palestinian children are not given the childhood they deserve, but is also tragic that the United Nations chooses to turn a blind eye to their horrifying upbringing.

There is no mission more crucial than protecting children, so it is heartbreaking to see that the United Nations permits hateful political agendas to seep into this topic as well. The deaths and injuries of children must be prevented at all costs, and they must never serve as pawns for the Palestinians' twisted anti-Israel agenda here at the United Nations or elsewhere. When it comes to protecting children, the time has come to stop falsely vilifying Israel and start condemning those who cynically and deliberately put children in harm's way.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Czechia.

Mr. Kulháněk (Czechia): I would like to start by thanking the United Kingdom for convening this important meeting. I wish to thank all the briefers. Let me also take this opportunity to congratulate the United Arab Emirates on its successful completion of its Security Council presidency and extend my best wishes to the United Kingdom presidency.

Czechia aligns itself with the statements delivered on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

We thank the Secretary-General for his recent report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363) and the Office of the Special Representative Gamba de Potgieter and other United Nations entities, including UNICEF, for their engagement in monitoring and reporting. The report underscores the urgency of acting on the children and armed conflict agenda, as violent conflicts worldwide continue to destroy children's lives.

We are deeply troubled by the number of children affected by grave violations in the past year — reaching nearly 19,000. We express our concern about the list of parties responsible for those grave violations across all geographical situations. We also take note of the addition of new situations of concern in the Niger and Haiti.

Sadly, grave violations against children continue to occur and are mostly perpetrated by State actors. That was evident, for instance, in the recent attack on a restaurant in the Ukrainian city of Kramatorsk, where children were killed and wounded as a result of shelling by the Russian armed forces. We strongly

condemn those acts and demand accountability for their perpetrators. State actors are obliged to comply with international humanitarian law and international human rights law.

In that context, we welcome the listing of Russian armed forces and affiliated armed groups as perpetrators of grave violations in the past year. I would like to emphasize that these listings are based on facts and collaborated by numerous independent reports from a large number of sources.

We also welcome that the report explicitly mentions the abductions of Ukrainian children to Russia, but true extent of that practice is greater. These violations must be investigated, and the Russian authorities must ensure the immediate return of the abducted children to Ukraine. We support the International Criminal Court's jurisdiction in the situation and call on the international community to intensify its efforts to expose it. In that regard, let me recall that tackling the abductions is also part of the mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for children and armed conflict. In order to prevent violations of children's rights in armed conflict, we must strengthen accountability efforts. All who are responsible for grave violations against children must be brought to justice, and we must uphold and reinforce the international legal and normative child-protection standards.

Czechia remains fully committed to supporting the protection of children's rights and to the children and armed conflict agenda. We urge all parties to conflicts to cease violations and work to develop joint action plans with the United Nations. We call on the Security Council to work closely with the Special Representative, including on specific country situations, and to incorporate child-protection aspects into its deliberations.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Bangladesh.

Mr. Hossain (Bangladesh): I thank the Permanent Mission of the United Kingdom for convening today's vital open debate. I also thank Special Representative of the Secretary-General Gamba de Potgieter and UNICEF Deputy Executive Director Abdi and others for their insightful briefings this morning.

The grave violations against children that we are witnessing in so many conflict zones around the world are a moral outrage and a stain on our collective

conscience. Despite the constant efforts of the United Nations, including the Security Council, there were 27,180 such violations in 2022 alone, a significant increase from the previous year. That highlights the urgent need for enhanced measures to protect children in armed conflict. We thank the Secretary-General for his comprehensive report (S/2023/363). We commend the Special Representative, the country task forces, the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism and the Security Council's Working Group on Children and Armed Conflict for their efforts in the release and support of 12,460 children associated with armed forces or groups.

Drawing on its own experiences of enduring the horrors of war, Bangladesh remains committed to protecting civilians, especially children, in armed conflict. As the leading troop- and police-contributing country for the United Nations, we have sent our peacekeepers to serve in many difficult situations to protect children from being killed, maimed or affected by sexual violence. Furthermore, they have been protecting schools and hospitals and ensuring their sanctity as spaces of education and healing. Based on our belief in the importance of such protection, Bangladesh has been providing shelter to more than 1.2 million Rohingya for the past six years. More than 50 per cent of them are children who have endured unimaginable atrocities and persecution in Myanmar. The situation in Myanmar continues to remain dangerous for children, who are often used as soldiers by the armed forces and other ethnic armed groups. It will be critical to address those challenges with urgency in order to ensure an environment in Myanmar that is conducive to the safety of all children. In addressing the guiding questions for this debate, I would like to highlight the following key points.

First, we firmly believe that it is our collective responsibility to ensure that children do not pay the price for the wars that are waged by us, the adults. We must take decisive and tangible measures to enhance the protection of those vulnerable children, who are among those who need our support most. The protection of children in armed conflict is primarily the responsibility of the State. States should therefore ensure that their national laws are in line with international human rights law and international humanitarian law, as well as the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its Optional Protocol. That includes enacting legislation that criminalizes grave violations against children and establishing robust judicial systems to effectively hold perpetrators accountable.

Secondly, we note the efforts to integrate child-protection provisions and capacity into United Nations peacekeeping operations and special political missions. However, the available resources do not match the scale of child-protection risks in conflict-affected areas. We urge for the increased and timely allocation of critical resources to effectively address the protection needs of children in conflict.

Thirdly, innovation plays a crucial role in addressing the evolving challenges in all areas of our work, including those faced by children in armed conflict. We need to explore and pilot innovative approaches that leverage technology, digital platforms and data-driven solutions to better protect children. Leveraging technological advancement for the collection and analysis of data to anticipate risks, and taking early action for the protection of children in armed conflicts, are therefore also very much needed. In that regard, collaboration between Governments, civil society and the private sector is essential to effectively leverage technology for child protection.

Finally, we must tailor our responses to the specific needs of girls. That involves investing in gender-responsive programming, empowering girls through education and challenging harmful gender norms.

Furthermore, we stress the importance of addressing child-protection concerns in early warning, conflict analysis, mediation and transitional justice, as well as in disarmament, demobilization and reintegration processes, as recommended by the Secretary-General. The role of the Peacebuilding Commission (PBC) is critical in that regard. We call on the Council to use the PBC's advisory role to identify critical gaps in protection in conflict-affected countries and recognize good practices in the rehabilitation and reintegration of the children affected.

Nearly 25 years have passed since the Council adopted its first resolution on this issue. We must do something concrete to address the root causes, so that all the children in the world who are suffering in conflict can have a protected childhood.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Slovakia.

Mr. Chatrnúch (Slovakia): Slovakia aligns itself with the statement made earlier on behalf of the European Union, and that delivered by the representative

of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict. I would also like to make some remarks in my national capacity.

We would like to thank the United Kingdom for organizing today's open debate on the issue of children in armed conflict, which remains pertinent, timely and highly relevant. The Secretary-General's latest report (S/2023/363) depicts a grim yet very real picture. The statistics recording verified grave violations of international law, including the killing, maiming, recruitment and abduction of children, can only be described as appalling and entirely unacceptable.

Slovakia reiterates its strong commitment to international law and the principles it is based on. Respect for international law is an irreplaceable tool for the effective protection of children in armed conflict. Its basic spirit, focused on the protection of the life and health of children who, as a vulnerable group, often pay the highest price in conflicts, must be fully respected. That approach must also be based on the fundamental understanding that it is not an à la carte option but an obligation of all parties to conflict. Slovakia therefore believes that it is crucial for all the parties to a conflict to fully respect international law, and we call on all States and other relevant stakeholders to reaffirm their commitments to upholding international law, including international humanitarian law and international human rights law. We also call for full accountability for grave violations through national and international mechanisms, including the International Criminal Court. All perpetrators must be brought to justice and held responsible for the crimes they commit.

We once again reiterate our strong condemnation of Russia's ongoing aggression against Ukraine, in violation of international law and the Charter of the United Nations and its principles. We note the new decision in the Secretary-General's report to list Russia's armed forces and its affiliated armed groups in Ukraine, which only confirms the information emerging from other reports of the crimes that the Russian Federation has committed in Ukraine. The listing in the second annex to the report, together with branches of the Islamic State in Iraq and the Levant, among others, is self-explanatory and needs no further comment.

Last but not least, we would like to reiterate our concerns about the meeting held between United Nations representatives and Maria Lvova-Belova, who is subject to an arrest warrant from the International Criminal

Court for possible war crimes involving the unlawful deportation of children. The Relationship Agreement between the United Nations and the Court requires that the United Nations refrain from any actions that would frustrate the activities of the Court and its various organs or undermine the authority of their decisions.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Germany.

Ms. Leendertse (Germany): Germany thanks the United Kingdom presidency for convening this important debate.

We align ourselves with the statement delivered on behalf of the European Union and the statement made by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

Germany is deeply concerned about the statistics and trends presented in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363). We strongly condemn all grave violations against children worldwide in all conflict situations. We urge all United Nations States Members to comply with their obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law and to do everything in their power to protect children affected by armed conflict. Germany encourages all Member States that have not yet done so to endorse the Safe Schools Declaration, as well as the Paris Principles and Vancouver Principles, and to ratify the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict. In our view, it is crucial to focus on reintegrating children who were previously associated with armed forces. We urge all parties involved to adopt and implement handover protocols that provide clear guidelines for the prompt transfer of children from security forces to civilian child protection agencies. Ensuring access to safe and inclusive education must continue to be a top priority throughout the reintegration process.

We are witnessing an alarming increase in child abductions and a distressing number of cases involving sexual violence against children. We must therefore address the gender aspects of those violations with even greater urgency. Germany remains steadfast in its commitment to advocate for adequate funding that takes into account the gender-specific needs in child protection efforts within United Nations peacekeeping operations. Supporting the victims must also include ensuring their access to comprehensive sexual and reproductive health services.

I want to conclude by emphasizing my deep concern regarding the dire situation faced by Ukrainian children. Due to Russia's illegal, unprovoked and unjustifiable war of aggression, a vast number of Ukrainian children is subjected to severe violations. We therefore commend the listing of Russia's armed forces as a necessary step. The perpetrators of grave violations worldwide must be held accountable and brought to justice. To that end, Germany and the Netherlands created the International Centre for the Prosecution of the Crime of Aggression against Ukraine, which will be based at the European Union Agency for Criminal Justice Cooperation. Upholding the principles of justice and accountability is not only essential for the victims and their families, but also crucial for preventing future violations. That applies to the situation in Ukraine as much as it does to all other conflict areas. For Germany, promoting children's rights and advancing the children and armed conflict agenda will continue to be a key pillar of our human rights policy.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Algeria.

Mr. Gaouaoui (Algeria) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to take this opportunity to once again express the best wishes of my country's delegation to the delegation of the United Kingdom and to wish it every success during its presidency of the Security Council for this month. I would also like to thank the briefers for their important statements.

The topic of discussion today is extremely important, as it concerns children, who are our present and future. Unfortunately, however, the level of care for children who are suffering from the horrors of armed conflict is falling short of our aspirations and goals. Statistics continue to indicate an increase in the violations that they are subjected to and in the harm that they undergo as a result of decisions and practices the repercussions of which they must bear. Therefore, I would like to reiterate in this Chamber Algeria's call to end the blatant and systematic disregard for international humanitarian law and international human rights law in armed conflict, as it impedes our ability and our combined efforts from protecting that vulnerable group.

Last month, Algeria was elected as a non-permanent member of the Security Council for the period 2024 to 2025. Algeria places great importance on the protection of children in armed conflict, as it firmly believes

in the need to save children from the repercussions of armed conflict and in the importance of raising a healthy generation that will uphold the values of peace and coexistence. In that context, Algeria has ratified all international conventions and instruments, including the Optional Protocol of the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict. Algeria has spared, and will spare, no effort to defend the rights of children and reaffirms its steadfast belief in the need to employ all means to ensure improved protection for our children. Algeria was invited to participate in the United Nations high-level event to launch a study on the evolution of the children and armed conflict mandate on the occasion of the mandate's twenty-fifth anniversary. That invitation is perhaps the United Nations way of acknowledging Algeria's pioneering role in that regard.

Algeria reiterates the need to adopt a comprehensive strategy that would safeguard all children everywhere from the horrors of armed conflict regardless of the circumstances. International efforts must ensure that no child is left behind. Children are our hope for a future where peace, security and development for all prevails. Clearly, much work lies ahead of us for realizing the protection of children and adapting to the changing realities that escalating and multifaceted conflicts impose on us. Change will be possible if we pool our efforts to uphold justice and the rule of law and address the root causes of conflict, including the lack of development and other related scourges, especially human trafficking and smuggling.

I would like to reiterate the following points, which we feel are extremely important.

First, it is important to respect and protect the rights of children in armed conflict. In that regard, all parties to a conflict must uphold their commitments to protect children and end grave violations committed against them, which will be achieved only when attacks on children, educational institutions, health-care facilities and other vital infrastructure are ended. We must work together to stop the use of explosive weapons and to bring about a world free of mines and explosives.

Secondly, we must hold the perpetrators of children's rights abuses accountable. The failure to reach that goal is a moral and humanitarian failure. We must always address violations committed against children in armed conflict so that perpetrators of those crimes that have been verified and documented

will be held accountable. That will be achieved only through close cooperation among the Governments and the country teams responsible for reporting and monitoring. Therefore, it is important to support those teams by promoting their capacities and providing them with the necessary funding so that they can fulfil their duties and mandates, without any politicization.

We therefore cannot disregard the grievous and systematic violations that the children of Palestine are subjected to as a result of the occupying authority's policies. We condemn in the strongest of terms those violations, and we call on the international community, especially the Security Council, to shoulder its responsibilities, provide the protection necessary for the children of Palestine and hold accountable all those who have violated their rights.

Thirdly, we must require maintaining the safety of children and their communities and support post-conflict recovery, which will be achieved only through stepping up investment in the protection of children who live in conflict areas. That includes prioritizing mental health, psychosocial support and reintegration, which are extremely important with regard to the protection of children, especially girls, who are subject to abuse, and helping them recover from the trauma of war. In that regard, we note the important role of the strategic outreach between peacekeeping forces and local communities to guarantee the safety and security of children and raise awareness to safeguard them from the dangers of conflict and its repercussions.

Fourthly, we stress the need to achieve a lasting and comprehensive peace for all. The primary objective of our Organization and of establishing the Security Council is to save future generations from the scourge of war and resolve conflict by political and peaceful means. It is therefore important to offer tangible and effective support to the efforts led by the United Nations to achieve lasting peace and activate all available mechanisms to that end.

In conclusion, we would like to reiterate Algeria's continuing willingness to participate actively and constructively in any international effort aimed at putting an end to the suffering of children in areas of conflict, including during our country's upcoming term on the Security Council. We stress that the protection of children requires everyone to act with the best interests of children in mind, work together to address the root causes of conflict and provide a safe and healthy

environment for children that allows them to explore their full potential and contribute positively to the global effort to achieve comprehensive security and sustainable development for all.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Malaysia.

Mr. Abd Karim (Malaysia): Malaysia would like to thank the United Kingdom for convening today's important debate. Our thanks also go to the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter, and the other briefers for their valuable contributions. The subject of the debate is important to Malaysia, as was reflected in our initiative in introducing resolution 2225 (2015).

Malaysia is appalled by the reported increase in the numbers of children who have been victims of grave violations in armed conflict. We are equally appalled by the reported use of live ammunition and excessive force, which have caused countless deaths and injuries of children. The increasing attacks on schools and hospitals have deprived children of education and health care. The denial of humanitarian access in various conflict zones has hindered efforts to provide children with basic necessities. It is alarming to note that a total of 38 parties to conflicts around the world, State and non-State actors alike, have no measures in place to improve the protection of children in compliance with relevant Security Council resolutions.

Ensuring the protection of children in armed conflict is a collective responsibility that requires the joint efforts of all. Malaysia urges all States to become party to the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict as soon as possible. We also emphasize the need to endorse and implement the Safe Schools Declaration and the Vancouver Principles. Our commitment to the Protocol and Principles is an integral part of our obligation to respect relevant human rights law and humanitarian law, particularly regarding children in conflict.

We echo the Secretary-General's proposal that the Security Council ensure that the provision and capacity for child protection are included in the relevant mandates of United Nations peacekeeping operations and special political missions. United Nations peacekeeping missions are among the most visible actors on the ground in conflict zones and play an instrumental role in the protection of children in armed conflict. The

work of the United Nations and its agencies, including the engagement between the relevant mandated departments within the framework of Security Council resolutions, remains crucial. Malaysia commends the vital work of the Country Task Force on Monitoring and Reporting and underlines the importance of a reporting mechanism that is credible, impartial, objective and transparent. The glaring absence of Israel in the annex to the report (S/2023/363), as happened last year, has continued to puzzle our delegation. Israel, the occupying Power, must be held accountable for the violations and crimes it has committed against Palestinian children in the occupied Palestinian territory. Malaysia reiterates its call for the inclusion of Israel in the annexes to future reports.

Impunity for crimes against children in armed conflict must end. No one should bear the burden of wars, let alone our future generations. It is therefore incumbent on us to provide them with the peace and protection they rightly deserve.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Belgium.

Mr. Bouthé (Belgium): I thank you, Mr. President, for the United Kingdom's convening of today's timely meeting and for giving us the opportunity to discuss this important topic. We congratulate you on your ambitious programme of work and wish you the best of luck with your country's presidency of the Council.

(spoke in French)

Belgium reiterates its unwavering support for the children and armed conflict mandate and for the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, as well as for UNICEF's Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism, which my country supports financially. Its data-collection process is the veritable backbone of the mandate. It gives it credibility and forms a solid basis for the adoption of prevention and action plans with the parties to the conflict. Those plans are key tools for ensuring effective protection for children affected by conflict. When tools related to children and armed conflict such as the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism are used effectively, and the integrity and impartiality of the listing mechanism annexed to the annual report (S/2023/363) are respected, the mandate can save the lives of those most vulnerable to conflict — children. We support the Secretary-

General's call for the adoption of a mainstreaming approach to child protection in all United Nations mandates and activities related to conflict mitigation.

(spoke in English)

Belgium welcomes the Secretary-General's most recent report on children and armed conflict. We share the Secretary-General's concern about the scale and severity of grave violations against children in so many places around the world. Allow me to expand on a few country situations.

Belgium welcomes the listing of the Russian armed forces and their affiliates in Ukraine. A swift and drastic reduction in children's casualties should be an absolute priority. We particularly share the Secretary-General's deep concern about the high numbers of attacks on schools and hospitals, and about the transfer of Ukrainian children to Russia. Family tracing and reunification, with the help of United Nations entities, should be a priority.

This year once again, the number of verified grave violations committed by non-State armed groups against children in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, especially in North Kivu, is appalling. Belgium encourages the Government of the Democratic Republic of the Congo to continue its efforts to implement its action plan, and we echo the Secretary-General's call to prioritize the fight against sexual violence, which remains an issue of grave concern in the Democratic Republic of the Congo, including when it involves the Congolese armed forces.

Belgium remains deeply concerned about the dire situation of children in Israel and the occupied Palestinian territory. The increasing level of violence in the West Bank and East Jerusalem is troubling. We condemn the Israeli security forces' excessive use of force, which has resulted in unacceptably high numbers of Palestinian children killed or maimed. Belgium is also gravely concerned about the continuing increase in detentions of children by Israel and reports of their ill-treatment during detention. We echo the Secretary-General's call for adopting and implementing clear and time-bound commitments to end and prevent any more violations against children by all parties and support his request to strengthen and broaden the Working Group on Children and Armed Conflict to cover Israel and the occupied Palestinian territory.

Belgium regrets that the gravity and number of violations by armed groups in the Niger have resulted in the country being added as a situation of concern. We call on the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, in close cooperation with the country's authorities, to look into ways on how to strengthen existing efforts to prevent a further deterioration of the situation.

Finally, Belgium is deeply concerned about the lack of meaningful improvement of the situation of children in Afghanistan. We support the Secretary-General's call on the Taliban and all parties to allow and facilitate safe, timely and unimpeded humanitarian access to children.

Once again, while the numbers of grave violations against children in the Secretary-General's report are just the tip of the iceberg, they are still intolerable. The work of preventing violations against children worldwide remains vast. Yet we all agree that we should protect children from conflict. Let us work together to safeguard and strengthen the children and armed conflict mandate, as it is more important than ever.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Morocco.

Ms. Moutchou (Morocco): At the outset, my delegation would like to thank the United Kingdom, in presiding over the Security Council for this month, for organizing this very important open debate on children and armed conflict. We would also like to thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, and the Deputy Executive Director for Programmes at UNICEF, Mr. Omar Abdi, and his team for their comprehensive insights. And we would like to take this opportunity to thank Ms. Violeta for sharing her testimony with us.

With the adoption of General Assembly resolution 51/77, on 12 December 1996, which created the mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, the question of the protection of children affected by conflict was afforded the international attention it deserves. That was subsequently enhanced by the formulation of legally binding instruments, including the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict, and enriched

through 13 Security Council resolutions calling for a renewed commitment to the protection of children in armed conflict and the prevention of grave violations.

In addition, ambitious and engaging soft law commitments were made with a view to strengthening the solid legal framework, in the form of the Paris Principles, the Vancouver Principles and the Safe Schools Declaration. Article 38 of the Convention on the Rights of the Child underlines the necessity "to ensure protection and care of children who are affected by an armed conflict" and to ensure that they do not take a direct part in hostilities. In addition, the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the involvement of children in armed conflict condemns

"with the gravest concern the recruitment, training and use [...] of children in hostilities by armed groups distinct from the armed forces of a State"

and recognizes the responsibility of those who recruit, train and use children in that regard.

Nonetheless, the reality that millions of children around the world are facing on a daily basis remains grim. There is still much more to do. We continue to be concerned about the scale, severity and recurrence of violations and abuses endured by children around the world. The findings of the latest report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) are appalling, particularly the fact that the number of children verified as affected by grave violations increased in 2022 by comparison to 2021. We are especially concerned by the fact that the highest numbers of violations are 8,631 children killed or maimed, 7,622 recruited or used and 3,985 abducted. And those numbers reflect only the reported and verified ones. The real figures are much higher. Indeed, as we speak, thousands of children around the world are victims of wars, forced to take part in hostilities as fighters, recruited and trained as child soldiers, including in refugee camps, used as human shields or exploited as sex slaves. They cannot speak up for their rights. They are threatened. They fear violence, stigma and humiliation.

It is especially alarming that non-State armed groups, including mercenaries and terrorist organizations, target children — the most vulnerable members of a population and easily manipulated and brainwashed — for their own criminal, terrorist, immoral agendas. They do so with total impunity and in defiance of the international community and human rights and humanitarian instruments. Children

forced or trapped into armed groups suffer a broad range of violations and abuses of their human rights, particularly their right to education and health, including mental health. They need to be taught about peace and coexistence, not war and killing. They should be on school benches and in their homes and with their families, not wearing uniforms in the middle of hostilities and so-called military parades. The recruitment and use of child soldiers, including in refugee camps, must end. Former child soldiers must be offered counselling and an environment conducive to their smooth reintegration.

International humanitarian law and human rights law provide an extensive protection framework for children in all situations. The problem is ensuring that Member States and armed groups implement and comply with it. The primary responsibility falls on Member States to protect all children in their territories, without distinction of any kind. The Kingdom of Morocco condemns in the strongest terms the recruitment and exploitation of children as child soldiers. We will spare no effort to support the international community's endeavour to prevent that war crime, recognized as such by the Rome Statute of the International Criminal Court. Morocco, as a State party to the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its three Optional Protocols, as well as the Paris Principles, the Vancouver Principles and the Safe Schools Declaration, is and will remain fully committed to the protection and promotion of all children's rights. We will take every opportunity to reaffirm that unwavering commitment.

Finally, we hope that this open debate and the strong commitments expressed today will strengthen international mobilization to effectively protect children from the six grave violations, including by preventing their use or recruitment in hostilities, while ensuring their best interests and promoting a better life for all children around the world.

The President: I now give the floor to the observer of the State of Palestine.

Mr. Mansour (Palestine): I thank you, Mr. President, for convening this important and timely debate on children and armed conflict.

We have once again received the report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363) with deep disappointment at the suffering of children around the world and at the dismissiveness of the suffering of our children. Once again the lives

of Palestinian children seem not to matter, and the violators of their rights are held to standards that are different from the universal criteria set forth in the children and armed conflict mandate. The Secretary-General's report mentioned that the State of Palestine was among the areas in which the highest number of violations against children were verified in 2022. According to the report, Palestinian children were killed and maimed by both Israeli air strikes and live ammunition, abducted by Israeli settlers, illegally denied access to medical and humanitarian assistance by the Israeli authorities and subjected to attempts to recruit them and use them as human shields by Israeli occupying forces.

All of those are triggers for listing, yet Israel was not added to any of the report's lists. The conclusion of the report does not match the data it verifies. It actually contradicts it. The decision not to list Israel is very offensive, and the claim that Israel was not listed because it supposedly decreased its air strikes — while ignoring the larger number of children killed by Israel in 2022 and the rising numbers of child casualties and violations of children's rights by Israel in 2023 — is even more offensive. Only days after the release of the report, Israel launched 10 air strikes on the Jenin refugee camp, a densely populated civilian area, wantonly and willingly endangering human lives, including those of children. Not only has Israel failed to uphold its obligations under international humanitarian law to protect the Palestinian civilian population, but it targets them deliberately and systematically, killing, maiming and terrorizing.

What is the Council waiting for to implement its resolutions and offer the Palestinian people international protection? When will it activate the mechanisms it has established to protect civilians? When will it pursue accountability measures that are known to deter such crimes, which endanger the lives of civilians, including those of children, the most vulnerable? It is shocking to us that while we are calling on the international community, including the United Nations, to provide international protection for the Palestinian civilian population — including children, of course — we see that the decision has been made to place that protection somewhere else, to protect Israel and shield it from any accountability and responsibility. Israel's reputation apparently matters more than the lives of the Palestinian children and the traumatic pain of their bereaved families.

Let us be clear and honest about the facts — the reason Israel was not listed is not because somehow its violations against Palestinian children have decreased or, suddenly, Israel decided to respect its obligations under international law. Previous Israeli Governments did not do that, and we do not expect the most extremist Israeli Government, with fascist elements in it, to do it now.

Not listing Israel is a failure to uphold the children and armed conflict mandate. It is an abandonment of Palestinian children. It is depriving the Palestinian people of the international protection they are entitled to. It undermines the universality of the children and armed conflict mandate and the credibility of the United Nations list worldwide.

Israel's so-called commitments, shared with the Special Representative of the Secretary-General during her most recent visit to the region, are simply empty words. Their actions, every single day, prove that. The United Nations Office for the Coordination of Humanitarian Affairs reported that 2022 was the deadliest year for Palestinians in the occupied West Bank since 2006, with Israel killing more than 40 Palestinian children. Since the start of 2023, more than 30 Palestinian children have been killed by Israel, and the United Nations has warned that if this pace continues, 2023 is going to be even more deadly for Palestinians than 2022.

It is evident that Israeli violations against Palestinian civilians, including children, are increasing in both intensity and occurrence. Look at what happened in May in the besieged Gaza Strip, where Israel's air strikes killed four children asleep in their beds. Look at what is happening in Jenin refugee camp, where four children were killed by Israel's brutal assault and many others seriously wounded, and where more than 3,000 Palestinians have been forced to flee for safety from the lethal Israeli onslaught. Look at the destruction there, the demolitions across the West Bank, the forced displacement and expulsion of families, the destruction of schools, forcible transfers, settlement growth, the racist and hate speech used by Israeli officials, the provocation and incitement and the settler violence, as witnessed in Turmus Ayya and in Huwvara. Look at the toll of those violations on Palestinian children.

It is very regrettable that the current Israeli settler Government was given another chance, another free

pass, to evade accountability and more time to kill, persecute and oppress.

Listing and delisting parties is a method created by the Security Council because the Council Members saw it as an effective method to deter, protect and hold perpetrators accountable, and it has proven an effective method for the past 25 years. Why is it that now, 56 years since the start of the Israeli occupation and with all the Israeli violations committed against Palestinian children in the past 25 years, despite being a standing item on the Security Council's agenda, Israel, the occupying Power, has never been listed for its violations against Palestinian children?

As long as Israel is not listed for its violations against Palestinian children, its commitment will not be serious; its violations will continue, and the credibility of the United Nations children and armed conflict mandate will be undermined. That is to the grave detriment of the Palestinian children who are in need of the Council's protection and to the detriment of our international system, which continues to be undermined by this ongoing failure to uphold international law equally in all circumstances.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Pakistan.

Mr. Akram (Pakistan): I would like to thank the United Kingdom presidency for organizing this year's annual Security Council debate on Children And Armed Conflict. We also thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, and the other briefers for their insightful statements.

Pakistan shares the deep concern expressed in the Secretary-General's latest report (S/2023/363), which portrays a harrowing account of 27,180 verified grave violations against children, is staggering. One in six of the world's children currently live in countries or areas affected by conflicts. It is evident that we need to do a lot more to ensure the safety, welfare and prosperity of our children.

It does not take much to imagine the horrible experiences that children suffer and endure in situations of armed conflict. It is evident that considerably more needs to be done to ensure the safety and welfare of children in such situations. In particular, children suffer immensely in situations of foreign occupation. It is therefore the most visible anomaly

in the report that the two blatant situations of foreign occupation — perpetrated by Israel, on the one hand, and by India in Jammu and Kashmir, on the other — are not listed in this report and given a free pass.

We just heard from the Ambassador of Palestine about the situation of children in the occupied Palestinian territories and the killing of children that is happening, as we speak, in Jenin. I must also point to the visible oppression of the children of Jammu and Kashmir by India's occupation forces. An entire generation of Kashmiri children has grown up in a climate of unspeakable fear, violence and repression. The human rights and humanitarian situation of children in Indian-occupied Jammu and Kashmir has deteriorated since 5 August 2019, when India unilaterally and illegally passed legislation to annex the occupied and disputed territory. We still remember the gut-wrenching picture of a three-year old Kashmiri boy, sitting in shock, on the dead body of his grandfather, after he was killed by Indian forces. It is estimated that 13,000 Kashmiri children and youth have been arbitrarily captured by the 900,000 Indian occupation forces in Jammu and Kashmir. Thousands of innocent Kashmiris, including women and children, have been killed in fake encounters and staged cordon and search operations. Children and youth have been subjected to torture and ill-treatment in order to elicit information or extract confessions or secure commitments not to participate in the Kashmiri struggle for self-determination and freedom from India's illegal occupation.

Last year Pakistan released a comprehensive and well-researched dossier covering accounts corroborated by audio and video evidence of 3,432 cases of war crimes, including against women and children, perpetrated by senior officers of the Indian occupying forces in Jammu and Kashmir since 1989. Those officials must be held accountable.

The Secretary-General's latest report has rightly urged India to implement measures, including prohibiting the use of lethal and non-lethal force on children, ending the use of pellet guns, preventing all forms of ill-treatment of children in detention and protecting children from sexual offences. We would also urge the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General to demand the release of the 13,000 abducted Kashmiri youth, whose whereabouts are not known and who we are told are subjected to torture to ensure that their families do not join the freedom struggle. It is only when India implements

these obligations under international humanitarian law that it should be removed from the report, in particular the list in the report.

As one of the earliest signatories to the Convention on the Rights of the Child, Pakistan is fully alive to its responsibilities under the Convention. We have undertaken wide-ranging legal, policy and operational measures focusing on the protection of children in security situations. Earlier this year, Pakistan set up a national committee for the protection of children and designated a national focal person in this regard. We have also recently endorsed the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers.

Pakistan supports the mandate of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General to deal with situations of children in armed conflict. However, we believe that the legal parameters of the Special Representative's mandate must be scrupulously respected. The singular focus should address situations of armed conflicts. In that context, my delegation wishes to state for the record that references to Pakistan in the Secretary-General's report do not fall within the purview of the Special Representative's mandate. However, despite our principled position, we will continue to engage with the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General to further strengthen child protection in Pakistan, in line with our national framework and international obligations.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Yemen.

Mr. Al-Saadi (Yemen) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, Mr. President, allow me to congratulate you on assuming the presidency of the Security Council this month and to wish you and your team every success.

I would like to congratulate Ambassador Nusseibeh and the delegation of the United Arab Emirates for assuming the presidency of the Council last month. I would also like to thank Mr. António Guterres, Secretary-General of the United Nations, and his Special Representative, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, for their efforts to protect children in regions of armed conflict. This issue is a priority for the Republic of Yemen, which is a country suffering from armed conflict. I would particularly like to thank Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter and Mr. Omar Abdi, Deputy Executive Director for Programmes of the United Nations Children's Fund, for their briefings.

The Yemeni Government has reviewed the 2022 report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363). We draw the Security Council's attention to the fact that national reports warn that Houthi militias have used the humanitarian truce in Yemen to intensify mobilization and recruitment campaigns, whereby they recruited more than 30,000 new children. At the beginning of this summer, the leaders of those militias stated that they are targeting 1.5 million children through the so-called summer camps, which is an effective way to recruit children and send them onto the battlefield.

The report of the Secretary-General refers to many violations suffered by children in areas under the control of terrorist Houthi militias. It is unfortunate, however, that the report does not refer to violations involving distorting school curriculums and establishing the so-called summer camps, through which thousands of Yemeni children are being indoctrinated, brainwashed and inculcated into extreme terrorist ideas of death and hatred. We are surprised that the international community has remained silent about the open recruitment operation being carried out by those militias, which is the largest in the history of humankind. That operation is inconsistent with calls for de-escalation and for bringing the conflict to an end. It is also inconsistent with all international instruments and norms. Rather, it reveals the true position of the militias, which are trying to create a time bomb, threatening regional and international peace and security.

Violating children's rights is not an unintentional sin committed by the Houthi terrorist militias; it is a deliberate tactic that lies at the core of their vision. For those militias, it is not enough to brutally violate children's rights and use children in armed conflicts and terrorist acts; those violations are a tool to paralyse and control Yemeni society and weaken families.

The Houthi militias continue to blatantly and increasingly violate children's rights, without responding to international efforts and stances, which have accorded great importance to that issue in Yemen. The Houthi militias are sending thousands of children to battlefields and military operations. They continue to open extremist jihadi mobilization and recruitment centres that they call summer camps. That behaviour is typical of racist terrorist groups. In the case of the Houthis, it complements their totalitarian vision

that belongs to the dark ages, in which humanitarian instruments — and civilization itself — are seen as a threat to their existence.

The Houthi militias have also been targeting the health sector by launching erroneous media campaigns that oppose vaccinations, in particular the immunization of children. As a result, diseases that Yemen eliminated some time ago, such as polio and measles, have re-emerged. The militias have also given expired drugs to children with cancer, which has led to the death of some of them. That is an issue to which the Secretary-General report does not refer.

Palestinian children are suffering various grave violations, including killing and maiming, by Israel, the occupying Power. Most recently, the incident in the city of Jenin and its camp led to the death of five children, amid silence of the international community. It is important that Palestinian children receive the protection they need from the violations by Israel, the occupying Power. That protection starts with adding Israel to the list of countries that are violating children's rights. It is important to hold Israel accountable for its continued crimes against the Palestinian people. Not adding Israel to that list undermines the credibility of the list and United Nations efforts in various conflict zones.

The Yemeni Government reiterates its committed to supporting efforts by the United Nations and by the country team in Yemen. We continue to cooperate with them to end the violations against the rights of children and using them in armed conflict. We call on the international community and the Security Council to bring pressure to bear on Houthi militias to stop their crimes and violations against children in areas under their control, including getting them to refrain from establishing so-called summer camps and distorting curriculums with extremist concepts that serve the agendas of those militias. The Yemeni Government hopes that the upcoming report of the Secretary-General will include those violations. It is important to take practical and effective steps to stop grave violations perpetrated against children in Yemen by militias in the areas under their control.

We also call on the United Nations and international partners to support Government programmes to rehabilitate conflict-affected children, help the Government develop effective programmes to

reintegrate those children into society and ensure their mental and psychological health so that they can live with other children as non-combatants.

The President: In view of the fact that there are 13 more speakers on the list, I encourage all the remaining speakers to limit their statements to no more than three minutes.

I now give the floor to the representative of Azerbaijan.

Ms. Ahangari (Azerbaijan): We would like to thank the United Kingdom for convening today's open debate on this very important topic. We note with concern that, as reflected in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363), the number of children affected by grave violations increased as compared to the previous year. As children continue to be the targets of grave violations, effective prevention and protection, as well as ending impunity, remains a constant global challenge and an ongoing imperative.

First and foremost, ensuring full compliance with international humanitarian law is key for the effective protection of children in armed conflict. Equally important is to provide accountability for violations, as wrongful acts left unpunished often serve as a catalyst for the commission of new crimes.

During its nearly 30 years of aggression against Azerbaijan since the early 1990s, Armenia committed multiple war crimes, resulting in the deaths of 10,000 civilians, including hundreds of children, mass ethnic cleansing and forcible displacement. The most notorious violation was the killing of hundreds of civilians, including 63 children, within only a few hours, in the town of Khojaly. About 700 secondary schools and more than 800 preschools suffered considerably from the devastating effects of that aggression.

The scale of the brutalities is also evidenced by the fact that almost 4,000 citizens of Azerbaijan, including 71 children, went missing in connection with the conflict, and that Armenia refrains from clarifying their fate. Most of the Azerbaijani captives were subjected to severe torture, including beatings, mutilation, starvation and humiliation. The perpetrators of those numerous atrocities remain unpunished, in clear disregard of international law.

Despite the end of the conflict, Armenia refuses to share accurate and comprehensive information about the thousands of landmines it laid on the territory of

Azerbaijan, which continue to kill and maim civilians. Ten children and youth were among the 302 citizens of Azerbaijan who became victims of landmines since November 2020.

No child should be robbed of childhood. Regretfully, in breach of the obligations on the protection of the rights of the child and international humanitarian law, Armenia has widely practiced the recruitment of children by armed forces and groups over decades. Of particular concern is the exploitation of children for hate propaganda and the promotion of intolerance against Azerbaijan. The continued practice of recruiting children and involving them in military training undermines the efforts for peace and security at the regional level.

It is important for the United Nations, as well as its specialized institutions and their respective mandate holders, to undertake the necessary measures to ensure that Armenia is held accountable for its wrongdoings and that it ceases the unlawful use of children for military purposes.

In conclusion, I would like to briefly respond to the statement made earlier by the delegation of Armenia. Its allegations regarding Azerbaijan's so-called blockade of the Lachin-Khankandi road and disruption of electricity and natural gas in its Karabakh economic region are false and provocative. Azerbaijan has never created impediments to residents' freedom of movement on the road or to the road's use for the supply of food, medicine and other humanitarian purposes, including access for the International Committee of the Red Cross. That is supported by abundant documented evidence.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ireland.

Mr. Ryan (Ireland): Ireland aligns itself with the statements made on behalf of the European Union and the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict.

At the outset, I would like to thank the President for convening today's meeting, as well as the briefers for their insightful briefings earlier today and their tireless work on this issue.

The report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) before us today reveals the grim reality of children in armed conflict. It tells the distressing story of a year marked by increased suffering and grave violations against children, the scale and severity of which should weigh heavily on the Security Council.

It was a year that saw millions of children in Ukraine have their lives upended by the Russian Federation's unprovoked and unjustified war of aggression, exposing them to increased risks of death, injury, abduction, trafficking, sexual exploitation and forced separation.

Furthermore, hundreds of thousands of teenage girls in Afghanistan found themselves locked out of second-level education under Taliban rule, a decision we deplore in the strongest terms. In addition, some 2.4 million children in Syria remained out of school and at risk of child labour, early and forced marriage and trafficking and recruitment into armed conflict.

In the occupied Palestinian territory, this year's report shows clearly how children on both sides of the conflict continued to bear the brunt of Israel's enduring occupation. It notes with alarm the high number of Palestinian children killed or maimed by the use of live ammunition during Israel's law enforcement operations in the occupied West Bank.

From Haiti to the Democratic Republic of the Congo, Myanmar to Yemen and the Sahel, the alarming prevalence of violations against children underscores the need for decisive action to safeguard their rights and to hold perpetrators to account.

In that respect, we commend the Secretary-General for including the armed forces of the Russian Federation and affiliated armed groups in the annexes to this year's report. That step is an important means of accountability in its own right, and one that can help deter future violations. We must therefore ensure that all parties to armed conflict deemed responsible for committing any of the six grave violations against children are held to the same standard.

Ireland condemns in the strongest terms, among other violations, Russia's unlawful deportation and transfer to Russia and to Belarus of Ukrainian children. We call on the Russian Federation and Belarus to immediately ensure their safe return. Ireland urges all parties involved in armed conflict to fully comply with their obligations under international humanitarian law, international human rights law and international refugee law, to cooperate with the United Nations to develop action plans and to end violations against children.

We underscore the need to refrain from using explosive weapons in populated areas and encourage all Member States to endorse and adhere to the Political

Declaration on Strengthening the Protection of Civilians from the Humanitarian Consequences Arising from the Use of Explosive Weapons in Populated Areas.

The impact of armed conflict on children is both immediate and long-lasting. It not only subjects them to physical harm and emotional distress, but also disrupts their access to essential services, robs them of their childhood and undermines their future prospects. It is our collective responsibility to break that cycle and to create a world in which every child can thrive in safety, dignity and peace, unburdened by the scourge of war.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Iran.

Mr. Ahmadi (Islamic Republic of Iran): I thank you, Mr. President, for organizing this important annual open debate. I also thank the briefers for their contributions.

International humanitarian law requires all parties to armed conflicts to take necessary measures to protect civilians, especially children. That obligation must be fully honoured by all parties involved. However, children are repeatedly subjected to a host of egregious violations. They are disproportionately affected by the devastating consequences of armed conflicts and endure unspeakable suffering. Meanwhile, children who are refugees, internally displaced or stateless as a result of conflicts are more likely to endure severe violations and other major abuses, such as recruitment and exploitation, sexual violence, trafficking and detention. Those flagrant violations not only rob them of their childhood but also hinder their future development, perpetuating cycles of violence and instability.

The latest report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363) highlights the ongoing disproportionate impact of armed conflict on children in 2022, with a disturbing rise in the number of grave violations as compared to the previous year. Regrettably, the Middle East region remains a tragic witness to the appalling violations against children, from Afghanistan and Yemen to Palestine.

In Afghanistan, the United Nations confirmed 1,797 grave violations against 970 children. The de facto authorities should ensure that all Afghan children, including girls, have access to education. Iran, as a neighbouring country and host to millions of Afghan people, has provided basic services such as education and health care to Afghan children living in Iran.

In the occupied Palestine territories, the Israeli regime persistently engages in the most systematic and flagrant violations of children's rights in the Middle East. In 2022, the United Nations documented a staggering 3,133 grave violations, affecting 1,139 Palestinian children in the occupied Palestine territories and the Gaza Strip. Tragically, 54 children lost their lives. As the Observer of Palestine mentioned in his statement, the true numbers of violations and victims are higher than what the United Nations has reported. In addition, the United Nations verified 123 attacks by the Israeli armed forces targeting schools and hospitals. Those atrocities clearly constitute war crimes and crimes against humanity. The perpetrators responsible for those abhorrent acts must be held accountable and brought to justice for their crimes.

It is imperative for the international community to prioritize the protection of children in armed conflicts. Regardless of children's circumstances, their rights, safety and well-being must always be safeguarded. Ensuring the protection of children in armed conflict demands a multifaceted approach with several key aspects. First, ending ongoing conflicts and preventing their resurgence are essential. That requires that all the parties to a conflict comply fully and effectively with international humanitarian law, which sets forth guidelines for the protection of civilians, including children. Addressing the root causes of conflict is equally imperative. Children are often coerced into participating in conflicts to provide financial support for their families. Tackling issues such as poverty and limited access to quality education and employment opportunities is crucial in mitigating such grave violations. Furthermore, illegal unilateral sanctions and economic blockades can exacerbate the plight of children in conflict-affected areas and must be addressed.

We strongly reject an unwarranted and unjustified reference made to the Iranian armed forces in the Secretary-General's report. Iran has consistently fulfilled its commitments under international humanitarian law, and our counter-terrorism efforts have always been conducted in strict accordance with international law and full respect for international humanitarian law.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Sri Lanka.

Mr. Pieris (Sri Lanka): Sri Lanka fully endorses the Safe Schools Declaration, acknowledging the critical importance of protecting education and educational institutions during armed conflict. We would like to take this opportunity to reaffirm our commitment to implementing that framework, aimed at upholding the rights of children and educators, and call on all parties involved in armed conflict to refrain from attacks on educational institutions. Einstein expressed the importance of education succinctly when he cited the line "Education is that which remains, if one has forgotten everything he learned in school." Education therefore is a *sine qua non* even in times of conflict.

Regrettably, the nature of warfare has tragically transformed schools, once safe havens for children, into deliberate targets. Innocent children face grave danger while travelling to and from educational institutions. Only a few minutes ago we were told about such happenings in Palestine. Moreover, schools and educational facilities have been requisitioned as military facilities and recruitment centres by combatant forces. Such actions lead to a decline in school attendance, higher dropout rates and diminished educational achievement, with serious setbacks for children. Sri Lanka joins a majority of Member States in committing to the Guidelines for Protecting Schools and Universities from Military Use during Armed Conflict, safeguarding the civilian character of educational institutions. While Sri Lanka does not recruit children into armed forces, as a matter of policy and as prescribed by law, it acknowledges its obligations concerning child soldiers under international law.

Education cannot be protected if places of education are not safe from conflict. It cannot be protected if those imparting knowledge and their beneficiaries suffer physical harm or the imminent danger of harm. That requires parties to conflict to exercise military restraint around school zones and to clearly mark schools as safe zones and adhere to the norms of the non-use of educational facilities as bases, barracks, detention centres or weapon-storage units, thereby changing the character of such facilities and not providing the protection required under international humanitarian law. The problem can be circumvented to a large degree with the availability of digital technology, which enables students to connect with their teachers and learning materials from the safety of their homes. Educational technology could be a new focus of investment for Governments or multilateral organizations working in areas of conflict.

Sri Lanka had to confront the distressing issue of child soldiers recruited by a non-State group that terrorized our nation for decades. Following the ending of such acts of terror in 2009, the Government took on the significant responsibility of rehabilitating 594 child soldiers who had been recruited by the non-State actors and reuniting them with their families. Through its national educational action plan, Sri Lanka enhances the capacity of trainers in psychosocial support, empowering them to effectively provide guidance and counselling to conflict-affected children.

In my view, in the context of conflict, the prevailing humanitarian definition of childhood, rooted in international law, lacks cross-cultural grounding and limits the potential of diverse solutions to address complex social issues. A nuanced understanding is essential to craft appropriate and effective strategies. Embracing the right to education becomes a beacon of hope for war-torn children, empowering them to heal, learn and reclaim their future. By investing in education, we can strive for a just and promising tomorrow, enabling resilient young individuals to overcome adversity and contribute positively to society. I will conclude with a very apt observation by Nelson Mandela, who said,

“Education is the great engine of personal development. It is through education that the daughter of a peasant can become a doctor, that the son of a mineworker can become the head of the mine, that a child of farm workers can become the president of a great nation.”

It is also through education that the children of great warriors in conflict become leaders. We must say it loud and clear to those engaged in conflict that our failure to protect our children and their means of education, even in the course of a conflict, can result in the destruction of a nation or even perhaps a civilization, and that education, not conflict, is our passport to the future. For tomorrow belongs to our children, who need to be prepared for it today.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Egypt.

Ms. Rizk (Egypt): We congratulate you, Sir, on your country’s assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for this month, and we thank the United Kingdom for organizing this important annual open debate. We also thank the briefers for their interventions, while we appreciate the focus that has

been placed on the situation of children in the occupied Palestinian territory, which is quite pertinent in this context and at this particular juncture.

We are deeply concerned about the marked increase in 2022, as cited in the report of the Secretary-General (S/2023/363), in the number of children affected by grave violations as compared to 2021. We stress the need to enhance international cooperation to strengthen respect for and the implementation of obligations under international humanitarian law and international human rights law regarding the protection of children in armed conflict. We are particularly concerned about the rise in the number of deaths of Palestinian children in the occupied Palestinian territory, in violation of international humanitarian law. Egypt supports all efforts to strengthen the protection of children and put an end to violations committed during armed conflicts, especially by terrorist organizations. We further reiterate Egypt’s willingness to cooperate in ensuring the delivery of much-needed humanitarian assistance in this area.

We particularly welcome the report’s recommendation of the inclusion of child-protection provisions and capacity in all the relevant mandates of United Nations peacekeeping operations. We further believe that obligations to ensure the protection of children in armed conflicts should be mainstreamed and integrated across all operational decisions, activities and processes of United Nations peacekeeping operations. As a State party to the Optional Protocol to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict, Egypt has enacted national legislation that reflects the obligations contained in the Protocol. Furthermore, our educational curricula and training provided to military personnel include material on respect for international humanitarian law, including the protection of children in armed conflict, with particular attention to personnel designated to participate in peacekeeping operations. The content is prepared in collaboration with the International Committee of the Red Cross and the National Council for Motherhood and Childhood and is mainly designed by our Ministry of Defence.

In conclusion, let me reiterate Egypt’s commitment to continuing to back every effort at every level, including through regional organizations, to protect children and to end and prevent violations against them in situations of armed conflict.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Andorra.

Mrs. Vives Balmaña (Andorra) (*spoke in French*): Andorra thanks the United Kingdom presidency of the Security Council for convening this open debate. We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General and UNICEF's Deputy Executive Director for Programmes for their briefings and Ms. Violeta for her eloquent and poignant first-hand account.

My country aligns itself with the statement made by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends of Children and Armed Conflict, and I would like to add a few points in my national capacity.

Since its establishment 27 years ago, the mandate on children and armed conflict has led to the release of almost 190,000 children. It is therefore a critical tool for our Organization in building peace and security. We commend the progress made in the implementation of the 21 action plans under way and the more than 40 commitments undertaken by parties, which are essential in making headway in peacebuilding — a non-negotiable sine qua non for the safety of children.

Nonetheless, the report of the Secretary-General is damning, with 27,180 grave violations verified in 2022. The issue is all the more disconcerting because, as of now, the situations covered by the mandate have increased to 26 and new and emerging trends indicate that Government forces are those now mainly responsible.

Such violations require a sound, consistent and unified response to change the situation. We welcome the commitment and perseverance of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter, and her Office in the implementation of its mandate. In 2022, 12,460 children received protection and support for their reintegration after falling victim to armed groups and armed forces. We must support and strengthen reintegration mechanisms, which are still falling short today, to ensure that they have the human resources required on the ground to continue their prevention, verification and reintegration activities. We are committed to strengthening our voice and actions to encourage all parties involved to ensure prevention, expand the visibility of the efforts of the Office and support protection value systems.

Andorra will continue its cooperation with the Special Representative of the Secretary-General by contributing this year to the financing of the publication

of the report on climate change and children and armed conflict. As every year, this debate evokes avid interest. Beyond the human cost, the destruction of infrastructure and the disruption of economic growth, armed conflict has a devastating impact on the education of entire generations. In that regard, Andorra thanks all teams on the ground that are committed to peace and security. We reiterate our staunch support for the Office under all circumstances and for the rights of the children it works to protect. We will continue our political commitment to education for peace. The future of our planet hinges on our ability to put these values into effect.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Lebanon.

Ms. Mrad (Lebanon): At the outset, allow me to congratulate the United Kingdom on assuming the presidency of the Security Council for this month and for organizing today's timely debate. I also seize this opportunity to congratulate the United Arab Emirates on its successful presidency of the Council last month.

We thank the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, UNICEF Deputy Executive Director for Programmes Omar Abdi and Ms. Violeta for their respective briefings.

The most recent report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363) confirms that the United Nations verified 27,180 grave violations against children in 2022. Those figures, which are perhaps much higher since they do not encompass the unverified cases of violations against children, are not only numbers. As the UNICEF Executive Director put it during the Oslo Conference on Protecting Children in Armed Conflict last month,

"Behind each of these numbers is a story of unimaginable child suffering ... of rights violated and rights denied".

Children continue to be disproportionately affected by armed conflict, and violations against them continue unabated. As per UNICEF, a staggering 315,000 grave violations against children in conflict were verified by the United Nations between 2005 and 2022. Unfortunately, in recent days, we have witnessed Israeli attacks on the Jenin refugee camp. In that regard, we refer to the statement issued by UNICEF's Middle East and North Africa Regional Director, in which she stressed that at least three children were

killed on 3 July, and many others were injured. We condemn those attacks and deplore all acts of violence against children.

Looking at “the list of shame”, published in the annex to the report, we cannot but realize that not every abuser and killer of children is on the list as they should be. While the Secretary-General addresses the situation of Palestinian children, documenting 3,133 grave violations against 1,139 Palestinian children, Israel was omitted from the list. In that regard, an article entitled, “Why Does the UN Chief Value Some Children More Than Others?”, published a couple of days ago by Human Rights Watch, caught our eye.

The “business as usual” approach cannot continue to be our guiding line. Children should be off limits, no matter who they are or where they come from. The lives of all children matter.

As for Lebanon, we have already initiated our talks with the Office of Special Representative Gamba de Potgieter to explore avenues of cooperation, with the aim of crafting a strategic framework programme at the national level for children and armed conflict. We look forward to accelerating the process of laying the first stone of that initiative, together with Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter and her able team.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of South Africa.

Mr. Passmoor (South Africa): I wish to begin by acknowledging the importance of this annual debate and, importantly, the Secretary-General’s annual report (S/2023/363), which sheds light on the continued high level of violations affecting children caught up in armed conflict.

We align ourselves with the statement delivered by the representative of Canada on behalf of the Group of Friends on Children and Armed Conflict.

It is disconcerting that children, as the most vulnerable members of society, bear the brunt of violence, displacement and loss during times of conflict. We have noted and are deeply concerned that grave violations have increased in Colombia, Palestine, Mali, Libya and the Sudan, to name but a few places. As Member States of this organ, it is imperative that efforts be concentrated to protect the most vulnerable from the serious consequences of conflict.

The international community, through various frameworks and conventions, has recognized the rights of children, including their protection, during armed conflicts. South Africa therefore remains deeply concerned that, despite those frameworks and conventions, perpetrators continue to disregard international humanitarian law and international human rights law. The report with which we are interacting today is a consequence of those measures and serves as another means to encourage accountability for States to work with the United Nations to protect children in armed conflict, especially from grave violations.

It goes without saying that the best course of action to protect children is to pursue peace and prevent situations of armed conflict. Yet until that ideal is achieved, we must be pragmatic in ensuring that the most vulnerable are not exposed to the consequences of armed conflict. Therefore, South Africa emphasizes the critical importance of the United Nations as a facilitator in protecting children in such situations.

We encourage parties involved in conflict, State and non-State actors alike, to work with the United Nations and its agencies to provide the necessary humanitarian support and implement action plans to protect children. We also strongly reject any actions that contribute to grave violations and are particularly concerned about the assertion in the report that State actors are responsible for the majority of the killing and maiming of children, attacks on schools and hospitals and the denial of humanitarian access, especially when they bear the primary responsibility for protecting children.

South Africa continues to see merit in further initiatives to protect children during and in armed conflict. We continue to support the work of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict and the critical report produced by her as an apolitical tool that seeks to protect society’s most precious and most vulnerable asset. We have also supported, and will continue to support, various campaigns, aimed at protecting children, such as the UNICEF-led “Children, not Soldiers” campaign and, more recently, “Act to Protect Children Affected by Conflict”. We also support the Security Council’s own Working Group on Children and Armed Conflict.

South Africa has advocated and will continue to advocate for the inclusion of child-protection provisions in peace processes and peace agreements. Similarly, we also promote the integration of child-

protection measures into the mandates of peacekeeping missions, which often involve child-protection efforts in conflict-affected areas. Importantly, we also place significant emphasis on initiatives that focus on demobilizing child soldiers, providing psychosocial support and rehabilitation for the children affected and reintegrating them into their communities. We were particularly pleased to note the rehabilitation of former child soldiers in many conflict areas.

States must uphold their responsibility to protect children both within their borders and in conflict-affected areas. It is crucial to strengthen legal frameworks, enhance child-protection mechanisms and invest in the rehabilitation and reintegration of children who have been affected by armed conflict. South Africa will continue to advocate for strong international mechanisms and adherence to them through active dialogues and partnerships in order to address the issue effectively. By working collaboratively with other nations, international organizations and civil society, we seek to ensure that children caught up in armed conflict are provided with the necessary support, care and protection they deserve.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Ethiopia.

Mr. Sabo (Ethiopia): I congratulate you, Sir, on the United Kingdom's assumption of the presidency of the Security Council for the month of July. We have taken note of the report of the Secretary-General on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363), and we thank the briefers for their briefings this morning.

Children are the first to suffer in any conflict. They also suffer the most and must bear the devastating consequences. Of the various legal instruments in force for the protection of children in armed conflict, Ethiopia is a State party to the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its two Optional Protocols and to the African Charter on the Rights and Welfare of the Child. Our domestic laws and policies are aligned with those treaties.

During the conflict in the north of our country, Ethiopia has been faced with extraordinary security challenges. Despite the challenges, our Government has made concerted efforts to ensure unhindered humanitarian assistance, with a special focus on children and other vulnerable groups. In November 2022, under the leadership of the African Union, we signed a peace agreement that ushered in a series of measures, including

on the disarmament and demobilization of forces and on enabling the intensified provision of humanitarian aid. We have embarked on reconstruction and recovery programmes, giving priority to sectors that address the needs of children, including in the areas of education and health.

We have also charted a clear path for accountability for alleged human rights violations. A cross-sectoral ministerial task force is implementing the recommendations we have accepted that are contained in the report of the joint investigation by the Ethiopian Human Rights Commission and the Office of the High Commissioner for Human Rights. We are conducting nationwide consultations on options for a transitional justice policy, which is expected to take its final form around the end of August, with implementation starting in September.

Last month, we received a visit from the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, whom we thank for her productive engagement with Government officials from various sectors. We also thank the Special Representative for her participatory working methods, which allowed us to react to the draft report prior to its finalization. It is regrettable, however, that despite our engagement, the report is full of factual errors and was not cross-checked with nationally researched data that would have enhanced its validity. It fails to address our serious concerns. That being said, I would like to reiterate Ethiopia's unwavering commitment to the protection and well-being of children.

Moving forward, our national institutions involved in the area will further scrutinize the report with a view to addressing all the relevant aspects of its recommendations. The protection of children is a shared objective that must be nurtured through constructive engagement based on facts.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of India.

Mr. Sharma (India): We thank the delegation of the United Kingdom for organizing this open debate. We note with appreciation the briefings by Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, and Mr. Omar Abdi, Deputy Executive Director for Programmes at UNICEF. We also thank Ms. Violeta for sharing her insights with us today.

Children may constitute only one third of humankind, but they are its future. It is our common and primary responsibility to protect them, as they continue to be the members of society most susceptible to suffering and vulnerable to volatility. The international community shall ensure a peaceful, protective and progressive learning environment for children. As Mahatma Gandhi said,

“If we are to reach real peace in this world, and if we are to carry on a real war against war, we shall have to begin with children”.

Over the past two decades, the Security Council has actively engaged in that pursuit and significant progress has been made in protecting children in situations of armed conflict. However, as conflicts continue to flare up in various parts of the world, children continue to suffer. It is clear that significant challenges remain to the effective implementation of that mandate.

National Governments have the primary responsibility to protect the rights of children, as mandated by the Convention on the Rights of the Child. Member States should adopt effective legal frameworks for the protection and promotion of children's rights. The aim should be not merely to protect children from child-related crimes but to provide them with holistic development opportunities, including free and compulsory primary education. We call for ending impunity for all actors responsible for inciting and perpetrating grave violations against children. There must be greater accountability and sincere efforts to bring the perpetrators to justice by the Governments from whose territory such entities operate.

Member States should adopt an inclusive approach to providing protection to child victims during the rehabilitation and reintegration process in post-conflict situations. Assistance to national Governments for capacity-building and strengthening legal and operational tools for child protection is vital. We note the engagement with parties to armed conflict of the United Nations, particularly the Office of the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, in line with its mandate. That led to support last year for the protection or reintegration of more than 12,460 children formerly associated with armed forces or groups, a positive trend that should continue.

We are witnessing a dangerous and worrisome trend in global terrorism, which is an increase in the number of children being recruited and involved in

terrorism-related activities. We need a coordinated approach to the child-protection agenda and counter-terrorism. Member States should demonstrate greater political will to hold the perpetrators of terrorism and their sponsors to account in order to fulfil the Council's child-protection obligations. We recognize the importance of having sufficient resources and the requisite number of child-protection advisers in peacekeeping missions for the effective implementation of child-protection programmes. The Council should consider incorporating adequate child-protection provisions and capacity into all the relevant mandates of United Nations peacekeeping operations.

Before I conclude, I also want to respond to the politically motivated and frivolous remarks made by one delegation against my country. I will not dignify the venomous comments about India with a response, as those who are soaked in bigotry will find it hard to understand a pluralistic society. We dismiss and condemn those frivolous remarks with the contempt they deserve. It is nothing but an attempt to divert the Council's attention from the grave violations against children that continue to be committed in Pakistan, as highlighted in the Secretary-General's report (S/2023/363). The entire union territories of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh are and always will be an integral and inalienable part of India, irrespective of what the representative of Pakistan believes or wishes.

Let me conclude by reiterating India's firm commitment to supporting the United Nations in its endeavours to protect children in situations of armed conflict.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Georgia.

Mr. Abesadze (Georgia): At the outset, I would like to express our appreciation to the presidency of the United Kingdom for putting this important topic at the forefront of today's discussion and to thank the briefers for their presentations. Let me take this occasion to wish the best of success to the United Kingdom presidency.

I would like to express special gratitude to the Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict for the presentation of the report (S/2023/363). We are deeply concerned about the report's findings, particularly the continuing practice of grave violations, which include killing and maiming; the recruitment, use and abduction of children; the commission of sexual violence against them and

attacks against schools or hospitals. We support the mandate of the Special Representative and underline that upholding our commitments under international law and redoubling national and international efforts are key for effectively addressing grave violations committed against children.

In that context, we welcome the international conference entitled “Protecting Children in Armed Conflict — Our Common Future”, held recently in Oslo, as well as the pledges and commitments it mobilized to better protect children in armed conflict.

Georgia continues to strengthen its commitment to relevant international legal instruments, including the fulfilment of the obligations under the Convention on the Rights of the Child and its corresponding Optional Protocol. We also underline the importance of joint international initiatives, such as the Safe Schools Declaration and the Vancouver Principles on Peacekeeping and the Prevention of the Recruitment and Use of Child Soldiers. We also stress the key importance of the implementation of resolution 2601 (2021) for the protection of education in conflict. Georgia is a party to and strong supporter of all these initiatives.

We are deeply concerned about the impact Russia’s illegal war of aggression against Ukraine has been having on children, who have been disproportionately affected by the conflict. In that regard, we fully share the views expressed by the observer of the European Union earlier today and align ourselves with his statement.

Unfortunately, the consequences of Russia’s aggression and illegal occupation are well known to my country, Georgia. The fundamental rights of the conflict-affected children in the Russian-occupied Abkhazia and Tskhinvali regions of Georgia continue to be violated by the occupying Power. Among the major concerns are restrictions on the freedom of movement, access to health care and the prohibition of education in the native Georgian language in both Russia-occupied regions. Instruction in Russian language has been imposed in all Georgian schools and kindergartens, which deprives thousands of children of the right to education, since neither teachers nor children speak Russian.

In that regard, let me stress that the Russian Federation — the Power exercising effective control on the ground — bears full responsibility for violations of human rights and fundamental freedoms in both Russia-occupied regions of Georgia, as clearly attested by the

21 January 2021 landmark judgment of the European Court of Human Rights. This once again clearly demonstrates the urgent need of international and regional human rights monitoring mechanisms to have access to both Russian-occupied regions of Georgia.

Against that background, while we reiterate our commitment to the protection of children’s rights, we call on the international community to urge Russia to cease its provocative and destructive actions in the illegally occupied regions of Georgia and start to fulfil its international obligations, first and foremost, the European Union-mediated 12 August 2008 ceasefire agreement.

In conclusion, let me stress the critical significance of the consistent and firm stance of the international community for safeguarding children’s rights in conflict-affected areas everywhere, including the illegally occupied regions of Georgia and Ukraine, so as to ensure that no one is left behind. Georgia reiterates its readiness to contribute to international endeavours to prioritize child protection in conflict-affected areas.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Argentina.

Ms. Squeff (Argentina) (*spoke in Spanish*): We appreciate the convening of this important open debate, as well as the briefings by Special Representative Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, UNICEF Deputy Executive Director Omar Abdi and Ms. Violeta, a civil society representative.

We also express our appreciation to the Secretary-General for the preparation of the latest report (S/2023/363). In that regard, we share the serious concern that the number of children affected by grave violations increased in 2022, compared to 2021. It is also alarming that there was a 112 per cent increase in attacks on schools and hospitals.

We strongly call for an immediate end to grave violations against children. We urge the implementation of all necessary actions to prevent them and stress the need of providing children with humanitarian assistance commensurate with their needs, based on a human rights-based approach centred on the child as victim of these grave violations, and of ensuring the adequate accountability of perpetrators.

Grave violations against children must stop immediately. The six grave violations against children identified in the Council resolutions flout the limits set

in international humanitarian law and defy the essence of human conscience. The international community must urge all countries to ratify and implement the Convention on the Rights of the Child and to increase financial and technical support in order to help the countries concerned improve their ability to protect children.

The military use of schools by parties to conflicts can have a devastating impact on children and can make schools targets for opposing forces. When a school is destroyed during an attack, it can take years to rebuild. In the meantime, hundreds of students may be deprived of their right to education.

To better protect schools, students and educators, States must support and implement the Safe Schools Declaration, an intergovernmental political commitment to protect education during conflict, to which Argentina, along with more than 100 other countries, is a party.

The United Nations agenda on children and armed conflict has a multitude of robust tools and initiatives developed at different levels to protect children from grave violations. One of the strengths of that agenda has been dialogue with parties to conflict, with hundreds of commitments, including action plans established by parties to conflict to better protect children.

We reiterate our strong support for the work carried out by the Special Representative of the Secretary-General, Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, in the exercise of her mandate, while highlighting the important work carried out by the Monitoring and Reporting Mechanism for grave violations, whose actions on the ground are crucial for the protection of children in armed conflict.

Achieving peace is the best protection for children. If war continues, it will result only in more violence against children. The Security Council can and must do more to protect children around the world. The Council must continue to seek political solutions to ongoing conflicts and promote the protection of children during conflict prevention and resolution. In addition, it is important that the Council speak with one voice in order to improve compliance with international humanitarian law, respect for human rights and accountability for all violations and abuses against children.

The President: I now give the floor to the representative of Bahrain.

Mr. Alrowaiei (Bahrain) (*spoke in Arabic*): At the outset, I would like to thank the delegation of the United Arab Emirates for its presidency of the Security Council over the past month. I would also like to congratulate the delegation of the friendly United Kingdom for presiding over the work of the Council for the month of July. We wish the delegation every success. We would also like to thank Mrs. Virginia Gamba de Potgieter, Special Representative of the Secretary-General for Children and Armed Conflict, and Mr. Omar Abdi, Deputy Executive Director for Programmes of UNICEF, for their valuable briefings.

In his report on children and armed conflict (S/2023/363), the Secretary-General welcomed the cooperation between the Coalition to Support Legitimacy in Yemen with Mrs. Gamba de Potgieter and the progress achieved in implementing the programme of the time bound activities that was adopted in January 2020.

Over the past year and until this very day, children have been subjected to gross violations in areas of conflict. The number of children who were subjected to such verified violations actually increased in comparison to 2021, as the Secretary-General stated in his report. The increasing number of conflicts, armed groups and hostile acts reaching new areas have directly led to increased gross violations against children, such as killing, maiming, abduction and recruitment, in addition to other heinous crimes against children, as well as increased attacks against schools, hospitals and infrastructure.

In that regard, we stress the need for all parties to conflict to respect international law and international humanitarian law. They must respect and implement relevant international treaties on children's rights, including the Convention on the Rights of the Child. All parties to conflict must ensure access to humanitarian assistance for children, their families and their caregivers, and they must provide children with health care, education and protection. We must also investigate any violation of the rights of the child, and we must prevent such violations and hold their perpetrators accountable.

The Kingdom of Bahrain, which is eager to implement all measures to ensure the protection of children and to promote their rights, acceded to the Convention on the Rights of the Child in 1991 and ratified it without any reservations on 13 February

1992. The Kingdom of Bahrain has also acceded to the Optional Protocols to the Convention on the Rights of the Child on the involvement of children in armed conflict and on the sale and exploitation of children. Accordingly, we stress the importance of including all States Members of the United Nations in efforts to promote the protection of children and spare them the scourge of conflict worldwide in addition to supporting the rehabilitation and reintegration of affected children.

In conclusion, the Kingdom of Bahrain will continue to support all efforts to protect children and prevent their abuse in any form. We will cooperate with the international community to ensure peace and security all over the world so that everyone, particularly children, can enjoy all their rights, foremost of which is living in safe and prosperous nations.

The President: The representative of Pakistan has asked for the floor to make a further statement. I now give her the floor.

Mrs. Ijaz (Pakistan): I take the floor to respond to the remarks made by the delegation of India against my country. It is unfortunate that the remarks made by the representative of India are emblematic of the malice that the Indian State practices as a virtue. India cannot hide behind false accusations and divert the attention of the Security Council from the real issue.

I would like to take the Indian delegation back to our statement, in which we quoted the annual report of Secretary-General on children and armed conflict, where he categorically urged India to implement the measures, including on

“the prohibition of the use of lethal and non-lethal force on children, including by ending the use of pellet guns, ensuring that children are detained as a last resort and ... to prevent all forms of ill-treatment in detention, [ensure juvenile justice and the protection of children from sexual offences]” (S/2023/363 para. 348).

We urge the Special Representative of the Secretary-General to keep on reporting on the situation of children in Indian-occupied Kashmir to prevent

grave violations against Kashmiri children from the 900,000-strong Indian occupation army.

While Indian occupying forces have been responsible for grave violations against children in Indian illegally occupied Jammu and Kashmir, Tehrik-e-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) and Baloch Liberation Authority (BLA) have been behind the terrorist attacks against children in Pakistan, including the cowardly and gut-wrenching terrorist attack against the Army public school in 2014, which resulted in the loss of more than 130 innocent children.

We have shared concrete evidence that the TTP and BLA have been financed and sponsored by Indian agencies. Captured Indian spy and intelligence officer, Commander Kulbhushan Jadhav, confessed to India's support to such terrorist and subversive activities. Moreover, India has sponsored and perpetrated terrorism and aggression against all its neighbours, creating terrorist groups, destabilizing and blockading neighbours so they would do its strategic bidding, and sponsoring subversion sabotage in terrorism in various parts of Pakistan.

The greatest falsehood that India keeps on repeating is that Kashmir is a part of India. This is a legal fiction. In all its resolutions on the subject, the Security Council has decided that the final disposition of Kashmir will be determined by its people through a United Nations-supervised plebiscite. India has accepted this decision and is bound to comply with it, in accordance with Article 25 of the Charter of the United Nations. All United Nations maps show Kashmir as a disputed territory.

If India has nothing to hide and wishes the world to believe otherwise, it should accept and give the United Nations Military Observer Group in India and Pakistan unhindered access to its side of the line of control, and if India has any respect for international law and moral courage, it should also end its reign of terror, withdraw its troops and let the Kashmiris freely decide their future in accordance with the Security Council resolutions.

The meeting rose at 6.55 p.m.